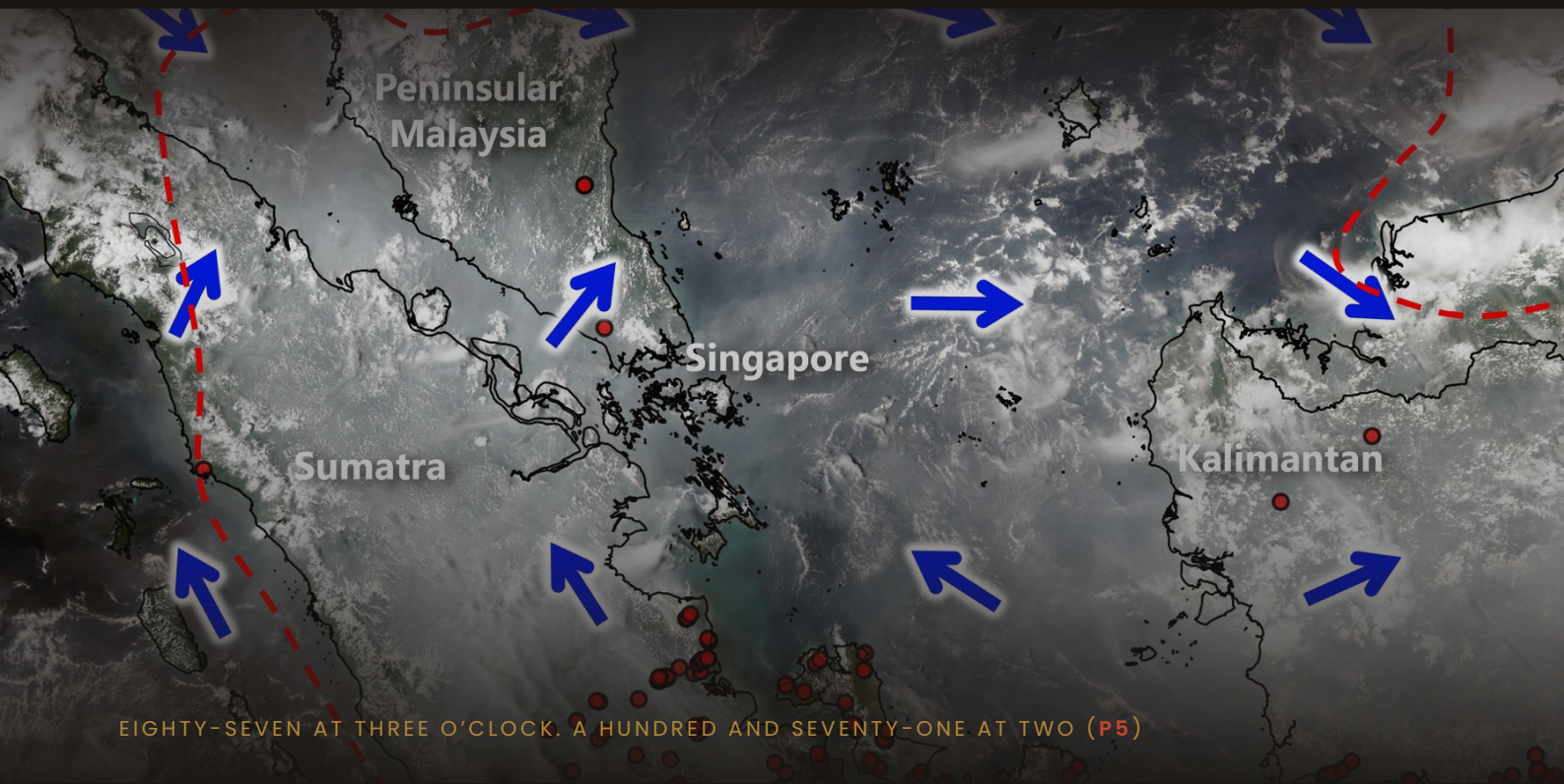


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 9 OCTOBER 2026



THE WORLD

Two French ministries counted the same arrested teenagers and came out a thousand apart
Twelve Desks · One World

THE RABBIT HOLE

The air-rifle ten-ring is half a millimetre wide, at ten metres, standing

Source: National Environment Agency / Meteorological Service Singapore satellite composite, captioned by the agency "Thu 08 Oct 2026, 2.25pm", published with its own haze situation update. Specific subject; hotspots, low-level winds and the moderate-to-severe haze boundary are the agency's own annotations. Cropped; no other alteration.

THE LONG READ

A country ran out of dollars in April, so it is dredging new land to sell

THIS ISSUE · NO. 127

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p21–23 The Long Read — the Maldives ran out of dollars, so it made land
No spine today — a straight news book, deliberately: no unifying theme, and a closing essay that argues one idea rather than threading several

FROM THE DESK

“Far better an approximate answer to the right question, which is often vague, than an exact answer to the wrong question, which can always be made precise.”
John W. Tukey, “The Future of Data Analysis”, *Annals of Mathematical Statistics* (1962)¹
An energy-drink market share where the question was bubble tea; a coil count where it was gauge; gross reserves where it was usable ones.

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY’S CLOSE

US 2-year	4.75%	▼ 2bp
US 10-year	5.22%	▼ 6bp
10-year real	2.87%	▼ 5bp
VWRA	\$192.50	▼ 0.43%
DXY	102.12	▼ 0.12%
USD/SGD	1.2806	▲ 0.11%
Brent	\$103.92	▲ 3.71%
Gold	\$4,134.50	—
Bitcoin	\$81,689	▼ 1.71%

Treasury series at Thursday’s close; the Straits Times Index closed 5,412.96, down 3.49%.
Detail on **p14**. Not advice.²

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FRIDAY

Micrograms of fine particulate per cubic metre in the worst Singapore region at three o’clock yesterday afternoon: **87** — p5
At two o’clock this morning: **171** — p5
Official Maldivian reserve assets in March, in millions of dollars: **1,331.8** — p21

In April: **717.9** — p21
Millions the president told parliament in February would come out of reserves: **150** — p21
Diameter in millimetres of the ten-ring on a ten-metre air-pistol target: **11.5**. On an air-rifle target: **0.5** — p15

Pieces to which three magazines said a new Bremont diver is limited: **250**. To which its own shop says: **none stated** — p10
Peak-arm dropout stated by a trial published this month: **14%**. Implied by its own figures: **25%** — p18

SOURCES ¹ John W. Tukey, “The Future of Data Analysis”, *Annals of Mathematical Statistics* 33(1), 1962, where the sentence appears in the opening section; Tukey, who coined both “bit” and “software”, was arguing that data analysis is a science rather than a branch of mathematics, and the line is his warning against the comfort of a precise answer. ² Levels at the close of Thursday 8 October 2026, each sourced on **p14**, where the Treasury series are the Department’s own published curves and the real-yield figure is its own par real curve. Gold carries no day change because the quote read gives none. ³ Every figure in the Index above is printed and sourced on the page cross-referenced beside it; nothing appears here that is not verified there, and no number has been rounded differently for effect.

THE WORLD • FRANCE'S LYCÉE REVOLT

Two ministries, one set of teenagers, a thousand apart

Turnout fell by seventy-one per cent on the day the government gave way. One ministry counts who was seized in the street; the other counts who was held in a cell.

Thursday was the fourth nationwide day of the French school revolt and by some distance the smallest. At 19:44 the interior ministry counted **71,500** marchers, **24,500** of them in Paris, against **250,000** on Tuesday — a fall of **71%** in forty-eight hours.¹

It collapsed on the day the government moved. The education minister told television that **“within the next hours, 3,000 teachers will be joining these institutions”**. Two hours later the prime minister put the figure at **3,024** supply teachers, prioritising **114** secondary schools. The student unions refused it and called the next nationwide strike for **Tuesday 13 October**.¹

Then the arithmetic that gives this page its headline. The interior ministry says **6,100** have been arrested since the movement began, most of them under eighteen. The justice ministry says **5,060**, of whom **87%** are minors. The gap is **1,040 teenagers** and neither is lying: one counts those seized at the scene, the other those placed in formal custody.²

The injury counts are firmer and worse: **215** teenagers, **85** school staff and **715** police as of Tuesday, and **504** further arrests on Thursday alone. The interior minister has suspended stun grenades for this movement after a fifteen-year-old lost a hand — while conceding only that a police grenade was a **“strong possibility”**.³

What the two sides are arguing about is a ratio. A student spokesperson: **“Until we have 10 billion euros on the table, we will continue to take action.”** The same day, the prime minister's own Council of Economic Analysis — twenty-three economists —

published its **first collective note since 2014**, calling for **€125bn** of deficit reduction by 2032. Ten billion demanded from the street; a hundred and twenty-five from the economists down the corridor.⁴

71%

FALL IN MARCHERS BETWEEN TUESDAY AND THURSDAY, ON THE INTERIOR MINISTRY'S OWN COUNTS — 250,000 TO 71,500¹

THE CHATTER • SYMPATHY AND EXHAUSTION, AT ONCE

A poll for a French broadcaster this week found **72%** of the public consider the students' demands legitimate — and **55%** think the protests should now stop. Both majorities are drawn from the same sample. The organisers' own count for Tuesday was **450,000** against the ministry's 250,000, and one rendering of their figure put it closer to half a million, so even the week's high-water mark exists in three sizes.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • THE GRIEVANCE IS MEASURED, AND IT IS REAL

The case against reading this as disorder is in the testing data: French fifteen-year-olds scored **43 points lower in reading in 2025 than in 2015**, the largest fall in the OECD. The case against reading it as costless is in the repair bill: **24** schools damaged by fire or vandalism will stay shut for weeks, affecting about **30,000** pupils, at **€20–30m**. Eighteen incidents have been referred to the police inspectorate.⁵

NOT ONLY FRANCE

Liège counted 107 arrests this month; Portugal's teaching federation has struck indefinitely since mid-September; Madrid's teachers stop on **14 October**. Four countries at once. The sovereign leg is on **p14**: the ten-year closed Thursday at **4.885%**.⁵

SOURCES 1 France 24's live file of 8 October 2026, read at source, for the 19:44 interior-ministry count, the Paris figure, the separate 55,000 and its quoted qualification, Thursday's arrests and injured officers, both ministers' quoted figures and the 13 October strike call. The 250,000 comparison figure is the same ministry's count for 6 October, carried by Al Jazeera and by RTÉ the same evening, both read at source. 2 The 6,100 figure is the interior ministry's, via Al Jazeera, 6 October, read at source; the 5,060 and the 87% are the justice ministry's, and the prosecution and dismissal figures are its own, as compiled in the encyclopaedia's running timeline of the protests, which states plainly that arrests and custody are not the same measure. This desk prints both ministries rather than choosing between them, and the explanation of the difference is theirs, not an inference. 3 Injury figures are the prime minister's office, 6 October, via RTÉ, read at source. The stun-grenade suspension and its quotation are the interior minister's, in a Reuters report carried by CGTN on 8 October and read at source; the same report records the government putting police causation no higher than a strong possibility. 4 The student spokesperson is quoted in the France 24 live file above. The Council of Economic Analysis note, its euro figure, its horizon and its status as the body's first collective publication since 2014 are from an Anadolu report of 8 October, read at source. The French ten-year yield and the spread are from a market-data service, read at source; a widely repeated claim that the yield rose above 5% in early October could not be reconciled — the same host's data stream gives 4.92% for the episode its own article headlines as above 5% — and is therefore not printed. 5 The polling, the reading-score comparison, the school-closure and repair figures, the inspectorate referrals and the Belgian, Portuguese and Spanish items are from the Reuters report carried by CGTN on 8 October, read at source. The organisers' 450,000 is from RTÉ; the half-million rendering is Al Jazeera's.

AROUND THE DESKS · FIVE CAPITALS, ONE PACT

The alliance activated, then two of three stepped back

Riyadh was promised rapid deployment on Monday. By Thursday Ankara called the pact “not an attack agreement” and Islamabad called a report of its jets fabricated.

On Monday the Makkah alliance’s defence committee met in Riyadh and its three signatories agreed, in the Saudi defence ministry’s words, on **“the rapid deployment of agreed forces and capabilities”**.¹

Thursday produced a contradiction that Riyadh’s own press then dissolved. The coalition said it intercepted two ballistic missiles aimed at the capital; the Houthi spokesman said he had struck the airport, causing **“a disruption of air traffic”**. Saudi Civil Defense reported that **falling fragments from an intercepted missile damaged a kindergarten and a medical clinic**.²

The air campaign is where the counting falls apart. The coalition spokesman put it at **324** high-value targets struck by **100** aircraft; the coalition itself claimed **82** destroyed on Thursday; the Houthi spokesman counted **156** Saudi strikes; and a Chinese researcher, quoted by Beijing’s own broadcaster, said **more than 1,000** — twelve times the coalition’s figure for the day. Displacement has two baselines rather than two counts: **200,000** since June on one UN body’s reckoning, **184,000** since 1 August on another’s.³

RIYADH — ARAB NEWS

Interception plus collateral. Civil Defense confirmed the missile was Houthi-launched and that authorities **“carried out the standard procedures for such incidents”**; no casualties from the debris. The coalition vowed the same day that attacks on civilians **“will not go unpunished”**.²

ISLAMABAD — DAWN

Confirmation and denial inside one day. The military’s spokesman told CNN: **“I can confirm that the forces of Pakistan are already there”**, in **“multiple capabilities and domains”**. The information ministry, the same day, called a report that Pakistani jets were flying against the Houthis **“fake and fabricated”**.⁴

ANKARA — VIA XINHUA

The foreign minister, on television: the pact is **“not an attack agreement”**, and **“Türkiye is not going to send its troops to another country’s territory and launch an attack there”**. Turkey’s own wire led that day on France’s offer to Saudi Arabia and on Turkish–French defence cooperation, not on any Turkish deployment.⁵

BEIJING — CGTN

The only capital carrying a figure far above either belligerent’s — a researcher at the China Institute of International Studies, cited for **more than 1,000 airstrikes**.³

PARIS — FRANCE 24 / AFP

France condemned the attacks **“very firmly”** and offered help **“in a strictly defensive manner, in the protection of energy infrastructure”**, naming Yanbu and the East–West pipeline, without specifying assets.⁶

And a seventh way of counting the tanker campaign: the maritime trade authority said on Tuesday there had been **nine attacks in the Strait of Hormuz in October alone**, half of September’s total for the strait and the Gulf together. On Thursday a tanker was struck **inside Qatar’s exclusive economic zone** — the first reported attack in the western Gulf in weeks, vessel unnamed, casualties unnumbered. Iran’s seven conditions remain, for a fourth issue, unenumerated.⁷

SOURCES 1 The committee meeting, the quoted deployment language and the pact’s August signing from Chinese state broadcast and wire reports of 6 and 8 October, both read at source; the casualty figures for Abha and Riyadh are the Saudi civil aviation authority’s, as reported by a Gulf daily on 8 October and read at source. 2 The interception claim and the Houthi spokesman’s quoted claim from France 24 and Xinhua reports of 8 October, both read at source; the kindergarten and clinic damage, the Civil Defense quotation and the condemnation headlines from Arab News, 8 October, read at source. 3 The four target counts are each attributed above to the party that issued them, read at source in Chinese state broadcast reports of 6 and 8 October; the displacement figures are the International Organization for Migration’s and the UN humanitarian office’s respectively, and differ because they run from different start dates — they are not a revision of one another. 4 All three Pakistani statements from reports in a Pakistani daily of 8 October, each read at source. This magazine recorded in No. 126 that Islamabad called a reported troop figure invented; the denial has since moved from the number to the mission. 5 The Turkish foreign minister’s remarks as carried by Xinhua on 8 October, read at source, and the Turkish wire’s own European file of the same day. 6 France 24, 8 October, read at source, for the French offer, both quotations and the two-sided battlefield count. 7 The maritime trade authority’s October figure and the Qatari-waters incident from Al Jazeera reports of 6 and 8 October, read at source. No source read this week advanced or enumerated the Iranian conditions.

SINGAPORE • THE HAZE ON RACE FRIDAY

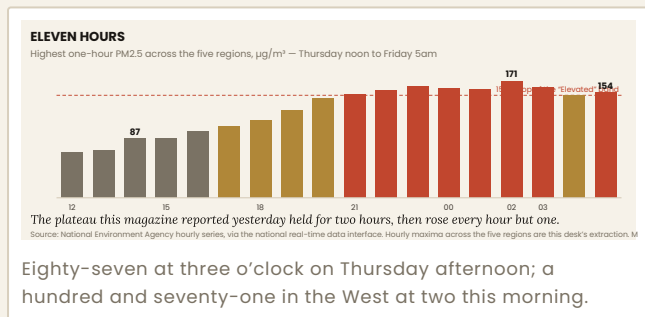
The reading doubled while the forecast stayed the same

All five regions were Unhealthy at five this morning, with the West at 171 overnight. The agency's published outlook has used the same three words since Sunday.

At five this morning the environment agency's own feed put every region of the island in the Unhealthy band: **Central 156, West 152, South and East 131, North 107.**¹

The hourly series is the story, and it is below. The island's highest one-hour reading sat at **87** at two o'clock on Thursday afternoon and again at three — the figure this magazine printed yesterday as a plateau — then rose in every hour but one for the next eleven. At **two this morning the West recorded 171**, easing only to 154 by five.¹

What that figure means is harder to say than it should be. The agency's own explainer gives a number for exactly two of its four hourly bands: **Normal is 55 and below; Elevated runs 55 to 150.** The overnight reading passed the ceiling of the only band the agency numbers, into one it does not.²



The outlook did not move with it. Thursday's six-o'clock advisory forecast a range it called **"High Moderate to Mid Unhealthy"** — the same phrase it published on Monday, with Sunday's differing by one word. Wednesday's and Thursday's notices both also carried this: **"The full extent of the hotspot and smoke haze situation could not be determined due to extensive cloud cover."**³

SOURCES 1 The environment agency's own 24-hour PSI and one-hour PM2.5 series, taken from the national real-time data interface through which the agency publishes them, read at 05:31 Singapore time on 9 October 2026; the five o'clock record carries an update stamp of 05:30:51. The overnight sequence is this desk's own extraction of the maximum regional reading in each hour from the agency's 8 and 9 October records, and the 171 figure is the West's own two-o'clock value, not a derived one. 2 The agency's published air-quality questions-and-answers page, read at source the same morning, for both stated band ranges, for the absence of a concentration range on the third band, and for the 24-hour index descriptors. 3 The agency's haze situation updates of 4, 5, 7 and 8 October 2026, each read at source; the quoted forecast phrase and the cloud-cover sentence are its own words, and the repetition across dates is a comparison of those four pages. 4 NASA's Fire Information for Resource Management System, NOAA-20 VIIRS seven-day South-East Asia extract, downloaded as data and counted by this desk inside fixed boxes for Sumatra and Kalimantan; the resolution caveat is stated because the regional meteorological centre's published series uses a different sensor at roughly one kilometre, and its own counting endpoint again refused this desk — a challenge page is returned the moment the date format is accepted. 5 Two overnight threads on a Singapore discussion forum, read at source; posts are quoted as written and the forum's own skew is noted on the page. The 2014 date for the inclusion of PM2.5 in the index is correct. 6 Ministry of Health, written answer to a parliamentary question at the sitting of 8 October 2026, read at source; both quotations and the registry position are its own. 7 Trade-press reports of the bill's passage on 7 October, read at source, including the quoted ministerial remark; the ministry's own media centre returned 404 to this desk and the bill text was not read, which is why no clause is cited. 8 The Land Transport Authority's own results document for the first October 2026 bidding exercise, downloaded and read as published; premiums, quotas and the prior months' figures are its own, and the ninety-nine-dollar gap is the subtraction.

And the smoke arrives from the wrong quarter. Counting NASA's detections inside fixed boxes, Wednesday gave **6,341 over Kalimantan against 2,368 over Sumatra** — near three to one, which is why Central has overtaken West under a south-easterly.⁴

171

MICROGRAMS PER CUBIC METRE, ONE-HOUR PM2.5, WEST, 02:00 THIS MORNING — AGAINST 87 AT THREE O'CLOCK YESTERDAY AFTERNOON¹

THE CHATTER • THEY HAVE STOPPED ARGUING ABOUT THE SMOKE

On the local boards overnight the subject is no longer the haze but the measurement. The sharpest line was the shortest — **"Will monitor what they put during F1"**. Those app figures are not official readings and are not printed here as any.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • THE HEALTH MINISTRY, YESTERDAY

Asked in Parliament this week about fine particulates and rising lung cancer in people who never smoked, the ministry answered that international studies do link PM2.5 to higher risk, but that this is **"often after long term exposure, and the effect of our periodic haze exposure will only be known much later"**.⁶

ALSO THIS WEEK

The Digital Infrastructure Bill passed on Tuesday — every data centre above **3 MW** licensed, penalties to **S\$1m or 10% of Singapore turnover**.⁷ And a **big-car certificate now costs ninety-nine dollars more than a small-car one**: Category A closed at **S\$130,001**, B at **S\$130,100**, against a gap of S\$2,500 in August — while the open category took **S\$137,000**, more than either category it can be spent in.⁸

THE ATELIER · MATTRESSES AND SLAT BASES

Four famous names, one Spanish company

The coil count on the label is, in the specialists' own words, among the worst ways to buy a bed. The number that would tell you something is almost never printed.

Start with the number on the swing ticket. The longest-running independent mattress reference calls coil counting “among the worst possible ways to buy a mattress”. What sets support is wire gauge — **12.5 at the thickest to above 16 at the thinnest** — with the number of turns, the tempering and the steel.¹

“Hand-nested” has a literal meaning: springs sleeved in cotton, strips **hand-cut and joined with twine**, against a synthetic alternative that is **glued**.²

Now the part the trade would rather you did not assemble. **Vispring** of Plymouth, the American houses **E.S. Kluft** and **Aireloom**, the retailer **And So To Bed** and **Marshall Mattress** of Toronto — whose 1899 pocket-coil patent Vispring was founded to license — are owned by one Madrid company. Four heritages, one balance sheet.³

At the other end the disclosure is in the filings. “our three largest mattress product manufacturers comprised over 70% of our production volume”.⁴

“The weight of the steel is probably the most reliable quality indicator, but it is rarely listed.”

Singapore narrows it fast: Vispring has **no showroom in Asia**, reaching the island through one Millenia Walk dealer that publishes no price, spring count or lead time. And the climate answer hides in a warranty — the local latex specialist's own terms **exclude humidity damage and will not cover mildew stains**. Plymouth, writing for Devon, supplies the rest: “Never use your mattress either in a plastic bag or with a plastic bag between mattress and divan, as this will lead to damage through condensation.” That is the verdict on waterproof protectors in an air-conditioned bedroom.⁵

SOURCES 1 The Mattress Underground's innerspring reference, read at source; both quotations, the gauge range and the list of variables that set firmness are its own. 2 The calico and spun-bond description is from a British maker's own pocket-spring guide, read at source; the latex process and the quoted phrase are from an expert article by a latex manufacturer published on the forum at note 1, read at source, and corroborated against the principal Talalay producer's own process page. 3 Ownership, dates and the revenue and factory figures from a trade-magazine profile of the group, read at source, and a furniture-trade report of the Toronto acquisition; Vispring's own site carries the group membership in its footer. 4 The quoted manufacturing disclosures are from the company's own annual report filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission, read at source. The contractor's name, the US\$1.25bn purchase and the three rival brands are from an interview with the reporter who broke it, read at source; this desk did not independently verify the supply relationships he describes. The 2024 acquisition is reported by the British maker at note 2. 5 Vispring's own store locator, read at source, returns no Asian result; the Singapore dealer's own site carries models but no prices. The after-sales exclusions are the local specialist's own published terms, read at source, and the quoted warning is the Plymouth maker's own care guide, read as published. 6 A Singapore retailer's own product listings, read at source, for both the price and the recommended price, and for the absence of a coil count or a density figure. 7 A thread on the forum at note 1, dated December 2019, read at source; posters are quoted as they sign themselves. 8 A British legal commentary summarising the competition regulator's settlement, the admissions, the earlier undertakings and the July 2026 judgment, read at source. This desk could not open the regulator's own text and does not quote it; the admissions above are as that commentary reports them.

76%

DISCOUNT RUNNING AS THE SHELF PRICE ON ONE JAPANESE-MADE POCKET-COIL QUEEN HERE — \$S1,420 AGAINST A STATED RECOMMENDED PRICE OF \$S5,999, WITH NO COIL COUNT OR FOAM DENSITY PUBLISHED⁶

THE CHATTER · THE SLAT PARADOX NOBODY HERE MENTIONS

Everyone tells a tropical buyer to use a slatted base so the bed can breathe. On a specialist forum, owners who got mould **within two weeks** found it under the mattress and on the timber: “**without airflow, there is a no chance for the humidity or body sweats to move off the mattress**”, and, from one who suspected the slats, “**it can be tremendously hard to get rid of once established**” — recommending a metal frame and no wood. The ventilation everyone prescribes arrives on the one substrate that rots.⁷

THE SCEPTIC · A REGULATOR WENT THROUGH THE SALE PRICES

Under a settlement this May, one large bed brand **admitted** showing a struck-through reference price **for a product never sold at that price**, and, in specific instances, one at which **fewer than 1% of its sales had ever occurred**. The regulator then asked the court for a rule of one sale at full price for every two discounted, and in July **the High Court refused it** — holding that low volume at the reference price is not by itself enough to make it misleading.⁸

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Reading lamps & bedside light — the warm, low end, and how a lamp is actually built.

Hand-knit & boot socks — gauge, nylon heels, and the lifetime-guarantee question.

Enamelware & camp mugs — vitreous glass on steel, and which chips.

TECHNOLOGY · SAMSUNG'S RECORD QUARTER

Two numbers, and everything that explains them is a guess

Samsung guided to its first quarter above a hundred trillion won. Its preliminary filing contains no segment breakdown at all, so the phone division's loss exists only as somebody's estimate.

Samsung's preliminary third-quarter guidance, published Thursday morning in Seoul, is two lines: revenue around **195 trillion won**, up 127% on the year, and operating profit around **107.4 trillion**, up 783%.¹

Every explanation attached to those lines is third-party. The release carries **no segment breakdown** — the two best-known estimates of the same unpublished number sit roughly **17 trillion won apart**: one outlet puts the finished-products division at about a two-trillion operating loss; another reports a securities-firm estimate that the mobile division's loss **could reach nineteen trillion**.²

Even the dollar headline is somebody's arithmetic. Samsung publishes won; the figure that travelled was “**\$80 billion**”, while the one outlet showing its exchange rate got **US\$76.7bn**. And “beat expectations” is true by **1.3%** or **0.7%** depending on whose consensus you print — while revenue **missed** by about 2.6%.²

The reason the phone division is bleeding is the reason the memory division is not. Twelve-gigabyte mobile memory traded at **US\$145–146** in the second quarter, up **175%** year on year, and rose another fifth in the third to as much as **US\$180**. Samsung sells that part to itself. On the same day as the record guidance, a Korean outlet reported the mobile division asking partners for **20 to 30% supply cuts** in the fourth quarter under the headline “**There is no profit even if we sell**”, with shipments forecast to fall from 59 million units to 52 million.³

A note on provenance. Samsung's own investor pages timed out and its newsroom returned nothing, so the guidance above is read from two Korean outlets, not from the company — a real limitation on a story whose point is what a filing does not say.¹

SOURCES 1 The guidance figures, the margin comparison and the first-above-a-hundred-trillion framing are from two Korean English-language outlets of 8 October 2026, both read at source. Samsung's own investor-relations and newsroom paths returned 404 or timed out to this desk, so the company's own release was not read, and the page says so. 2 The two divisional estimates, the dollar conversions and both consensus figures are from the same two reports, read at source; the seventeen-trillion gap and the dollar equivalent are this desk's subtraction. 3 The memory prices, the requested supply cuts, the quoted headline and the shipment forecasts are from the second of those outlets, 8 October 2026, read at source, which attributes the pricing to a market-research firm and the quotation to an unnamed industry source. 4 All five figures and the three denominators are read at source from the evaluator's own model pages and index on 9 October 2026; the comparison of its leaderboard rows against its own update posts is this desk's. The models are not named here because the point is the instrument, not the vendors, and this magazine is produced using a model made by one of the companies involved. 5 Both announcements and both quoted phrases are from the laboratories' own pages of 5 and 6 October 2026, read at source; the absence of a repository was checked against the first lab's own public model listing the same morning. The forum scores are from the site's own programming interface. 6 The bureau's own news listing and the company's own newsroom index, both read at source on 9 October 2026.

17tn won

GAP BETWEEN TWO PUBLISHED ESTIMATES OF THE SAME UNDISCLOSED DIVISIONAL RESULT — ABOUT THIRTEEN BILLION US DOLLARS OF DISAGREEMENT ABOUT A NUMBER NOBODY HAS²

THE CHATTER · THE RANKING THAT DISAGREES WITH ITSELF

An independent evaluator's index is being cited in launch copy this month, and its own pages do not agree. One model's page shows **66.97% ±0.89, ranked third of 45**; the same page's September update says that model placed **first of 63 at 69.69%**. A second model reads **67.04%** on the leaderboard against **69.22%** in its own write-up. The leader's margin over second place is **1.86 points** against a published error bar of **±0.97**.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · TWO OPEN-WEIGHT PROMISES, NEITHER KEPT

A French lab announced a trillion-parameter model on Monday to the top of Hacker News — 2,026 points — saying only that “**weights drop end of this month**”. No licence, no date, no repository: its public model page lists nothing of the kind today. An American lab's 501-billion-parameter release, five days earlier, promises Apache licensing in the future tense, sits behind a waitlist pending red-teaming, publishes **no hardware requirement and no quantisation guidance**, and quietly revised its benchmark table after publication.⁵

CHECKED AND FOUND ABSENT

No new export-control rule landed in the window. The American bureau's own news page lists exactly one item dated 1 to 9 October: an administrative enforcement settlement on 2 October. An eleven-billion-dollar infrastructure deal carried this week by the trade press is dated **24 September** in the company's own newsroom.⁶

NO SEGMENTS

TWO CONSENSUS FIGURES

THE HOME LAB · THE EXPERT CACHE

It merged at one-point-eight times. Two testers measured it slower

The multi-GPU expert cache landed on Thursday with a 1.85× decode gain from its author — and prompt processing down 27%, a 200% slowdown from one tester and a 29% loss from another.

Pull request 30112 merged to llama.cpp's master branch on Thursday, extending the mixture-of-experts cache this magazine covered yesterday across more than one GPU. On the author's own bench — two RTX 4090s, an EPYC host, a 93.7-gibibyte model with 65 gibibytes of experts — decode went from **34.78 to 60.38 tokens a second** with a 6.5-gigabyte cache, and to **64.39** with a fifteen-gigabyte one.¹

The headline omits the other column. On the same runs prompt processing fell from **440.7 to 402.0** and then to **321.5** tokens a second — a **27% loss** at the faster setting.¹

Then the thread. One tester reported the opposite result on a different model the day it merged: prompt processing about ten per cent slower and generation **"200% slower, 33 -> 16 t/s"**, with his own logs showing a cache hit rate of **43.54%** against the author's 85.9 and 95.8. **No maintainer answered him on the page.**¹

The second failure to reproduce is better instrumented, and comes from a rival implementation. On three RTX PRO cards and a twelve-channel EPYC, that author measured generation falling from **41.7 to 29.7 tokens a second** with a six-gigabyte cache on master — 29% down at a 60.6% hit rate — and explained why: **"without the cache, the CPU computes the same experts directly from DDR5, which is faster here."** He also notes, to his credit, that he had a language model tidy his results table.²

A third design for the same feature opened on Monday. The live argument is not whether expert caching works but who controls the size: one contributor found that tying the cache to the tensor split leaves **"the secondary card... 0 MB cache, even though it has gigabytes of free VRAM"**.¹

Apple silicon had the cleaner week. A Metal change merged Sunday takes batched decode on an M3 Ultra from **38.6 to 119.7** tokens a second at batch eight, with speculative decoding on code going **30.2 to 110.0** and perplexity unchanged to four decimal places. The maintainer measured the patch's second half on his own M2 Ultra at **93.35 against 93.63** — **"I don't measure noticeable improvement"** — and that half was cut before merge, so the title still advertises something that did not ship.³

94 t/s

THE BEST MEASURED FIGURE IN THE REPOSITORY BEHIND A 931-POINT CLAIM OF "125B ON AN RTX 4090 AT 100 T/S" — AND IT IS A TWO-BIT QUANT ON A 12GB RTX 5070⁴

THE CHATTER · THE TOP OF THE FORUM, CHECKED

The week's loudest home-lab headline promised a 125-billion-parameter model on an RTX 4090 at a hundred tokens a second. **The repository it links to never benchmarks a 4090.** Its measured table is a 12GB RTX 5070 — **94 t/s at Q2_0**, 79 at IQ2_XS, 53 at IQ3_S — and the only three-digit number on the page is a projection for a different card, prefaced **"should"**. The rows were run on **different engine versions** and are not comparable to each other. The honest figure is buried further down: a four-bit quant **"writes only 7-8.5 tokens/s"** on a 64GB machine, which may **"stop responding for 1-3 minutes"** while loading.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · A SUB-ONE-BIT CLAIM WITH NO LOSS FIGURE

A corporate research lab's compression repository reached the forum on Thursday claiming a design **"for 1.0 to 0.1 bits per weight"**, including **"the 0.1 bits-per-weight setting"**. It publishes **no perplexity figure, no memory footprint, no inference speed and no accuracy caveat**, lists no support for the formats a home lab actually runs, and is framework-specific. A tenth of a bit per weight is an extraordinary claim; the quantity it would cost you is the one number absent.⁵

SOURCES 1 Pull request 30112 in the llama.cpp repository, its description, its benchmark tables and its full comment thread, read at source on 9 October 2026; the author's hardware, both cache sizes, all six throughput figures, the hit rates, the quoted tester reports and the quoted exchange on per-device sizing are as posted there. That no maintainer replied to the failing tester is a statement about the page as read. 2 Pull request 29963 in the same repository, open and in draft, read at source; the rig description, the two throughput comparisons, the hit rate, the quoted explanation, the prompt-processing figures and the author's own note about how his table was prepared are his own. 3 Pull request 29869, merged 5 October 2026, read at source; all batched and speculative figures, the perplexity comparison, the maintainer's own measurement and his quoted remark are as posted, as is the removal of the second change before merge. 4 The forum submission and its score are from the site's own programming interface; every figure, the quoted projection, the engine-version caveat and the two quoted qualifications are read at source in the repository's own documentation. 5 The repository and both quoted claims, read at source on 9 October 2026, together with the absence of every figure listed.

THE KIT · BOSE'S WIRED RETURN

The earbud that cannot say whether it has a battery

Ninety-nine US dollars, a USB-C plug and no charging — except in the specification table, which says it is rechargeable and ships a charger.

Preorders opened this week on a wired Bose earbud: **US\$99**, USB-C, IPX4, with Quiet, Aware and off selectable on an in-line remote. The pitch is the absence — noise cancelling with nothing to charge, drawing what it needs from the phone. Bose puts it in three words on the page: **“No charging needed.”**¹

Scroll down the same page and the specification table says **“Rechargeable: Yes”** and **“Charging Accessory included: Yes”**. Both readings sit on the same page, in two countries, and the page reconciles them nowhere.¹

What is missing matters more. Bose publishes **no attenuation figure in decibels** on any regional page — for a product sold on noise cancelling. It publishes **no current and no power draw**, in milliamps or milliwatts, which is the one number that decides what this thing costs a phone over a long flight, on a device whose entire argument is that it carries no battery of its own.¹

The geography is its own puzzle. Bose's Australian storefront lists the same reference at **A\$169.95**. Singapore cannot buy it at any price: the local store loads, sells and discounts — QuietComfort Ultra headphones down to **S\$499** — and does not carry this model at all.²

Nobody has measured any of it, because nothing has shipped; the first units are due on **15 October**. No teardown, no attenuation curve, no owner thread — a press cycle built on a specification sheet that disagrees with itself.³

0 dB

NOISE-CANCELLATION FIGURES BOSE PUBLISHES FOR A NOISE-CANCELLING PRODUCT — ALONGSIDE NO POWER DRAW, NO FREQUENCY RESPONSE AND NO MICROPHONE COUNT¹

SOURCES 1 Bose's own United States product page for the Noise Cancelling Wired Earbuds, read at source on 9 October 2026: the price, the preorder state, the quoted marketing line, the quoted power sentence and adaptor warning, and the two specification rows quoted are all its own words, as is the absence of every figure listed. The ingress rating, materials and box contents are from the same table. 2 Bose's Australian product page for the same reference, read at source, for the Australian figure; Bose's Singapore storefront, read at source the same morning, for the two discounted prices and for the model's absence from it. No currency conversion is attempted between the two listed prices, because neither page states its tax treatment. 3 Jon Fingas, writing on 28 September 2026, read at source, for the ship date and both quotations; the microphone count and sample rate reported there appear on no Bose page this desk could find and are not printed as specification. Reddit refused every route attempted — the search layer rejects the domain and both direct fetches were blocked — so no forum sentiment is reported for this desk this issue. 4 Marshall's own Singapore product page for the Bromley 150, retrieved and read as served on 9 October 2026, for the currency keys, the inventory row and the pre-order state, and its United States page for the price and shipping window; the full specification is Marshall's own published table. The Samsung quotations are from a trade report of 8 October 2026, read at source, quoting a company spokesperson; the earlier compatibility statement is quoted there in the same piece.

THE CHATTER · THERE ISN'T ANY, AND THAT IS THE POINT

No owner thread exists; the product does not arrive for six days. The one hedge on record belongs to the reviewer who broke it, who says the buds are **“in theory”** a way to get the features without Bluetooth or a charge, then adds the obvious: **“Wires tangle.”** His piece carries no listening impressions and no measurements. And for a second consecutive build this desk could not reach the forums at all — every route to Reddit was refused.³

THE SCEPTIC · TWO MORE PAGES THAT ARGUE WITH THEMSELVES

Marshall's Bromley 150 carries a Singapore product page with a working “Add to Bag” — and the record behind it prices the speaker in **US dollars**, off an inventory row flagged to **China**, marked not pre-orderable while the American page sells pre-orders only. And **Samsung**, days after saying the SmartTag3 worked with Android generally, told a reporter: **“SmartTag3 currently connects to and works only with Galaxy devices among Android smartphones”**. It still works on an iPhone.⁴

SPECIFIED IN FULL, AND STILL UNANSWERABLE

Marshall Bromley 150, US\$499.99, shipping mid-October. Published to the millimetre: 42 Hz–20 kHz, IP55, 6.3 kg, 40-plus hours on a replaceable lithium-iron-phosphate cell. Unpublished: **the volume at which those forty hours were measured**, and why **200 W of amplification** drives drivers rated 40 W and 6 W and 6 W.⁴

Still held: Singapore prices for the Huawei FreeBuds Neo, now a seventh issue; and for the Ray-Ban Meta Audio and the MINIX, a third.

US\$99

NO SG LISTING

SHIPS 15 OCT

THE GOOD LIFE · BREMONT'S BLUE CERAMIC

The dearest one is the one nobody called limited

Three magazines printed a 250-piece edition on Wednesday. Bremont's own shop prints no limitation at all — on a page where the cheaper white model says 150.

Wednesday brought the Supermarine Full Ceramic Deep Blue: **43mm** of matte blue ceramic over titanium, **74g**, a Sellita-based calibre good for **56 hours**, and **500m** with a helium escape valve. Three watch titles read the same press material and printed the same clause — limited to **250 pieces**.¹

The maker's own shelves decline to say it. On Bremont's American storefront this morning the three Deep Blue references sit at **US\$7,400** with no limitation on the card, while four cards along Polar White carries "**Limited to 150 pieces**" at **US\$6,950**.²

So the collection's dearest watch is the only one its maker will not call scarce — and that is before the ladder crosses a border. In Britain, Deep Blue and the 150-piece Polar White are both **£6,450**, level, with Tactical Black £500 beneath. In America the three run **\$7,400 / \$6,950 / \$6,450**: the unlimited watch sits **\$450 above** the limited one. Open a different country's page and the hierarchy rearranges itself.³

"Its Sellita movement is somewhat outgunned in this peer group."

The sum everybody will reach for cannot be done. US\$7,400 against £6,450 is **1.147**, a rate sterling has not touched this year — but the American figure is recorded as *excluding* tax, and the British page nowhere says whether VAT sits inside its number.³

Singapore gets neither a price nor a door. The en-sg path returns a 404, and the brand's own locator loads empty and files Singapore among its *currencies* rather than its territories.⁴

SOURCES 1 Brandon Moore's hands-on for SJX Watches, 8 October 2026, read at source, for the case dimensions, the weight, the calibre and its base, the power reserve, the depth rating, the note that the US figure excludes tax, and every quoted judgement. Monochrome and Fratello, both 8 October and both read at source, agree on the specification and differ by hundredths of a millimetre on thickness (12.98 against 13). 2 Bremont's own United States storefront, the Supermarine Full Ceramic collection page, read at source on 9 October 2026: seven priced cards, of which the two Polar White entries carry the limitation text quoted and the three Deep Blue entries carry none. The Jungle Green limitation and the absence of a price for it are from the feature section of the same page. 3 Bremont's own sterling collection page, read at source the same morning, for all three sterling figures; the page states no VAT treatment, which is why no cross-currency spread is printed here. The 1.147 ratio is this desk's division of the two published figures and is offered as the thing that cannot be interpreted, not as a finding. 4 The en-sg path and the stockists path both returned 404 to this desk; the store locator rendered without results, and Singapore appears in the currency selector. The pre-owned figure is a Chrono24 Singapore search summary — the model page itself returned 403 and was not read, so the number is carried as a listing, not a market price. 5 Armin Strom's own Tribute³ collection page, read at source, for the reference, metal, dimensions, calibre, component count, depth rating, edition size and the single Swiss-franc price; the lug-to-lug conflict is between that page and Fratello's hands-on of the same day, which prints 44.35mm. 6 The comment threads beneath the Fratello and Monochrome articles of 8 October, read at source; commenters are named as they sign themselves. 7 Lex Stolk's hands-on for Fratello, 7 October 2026, read at source, for both references, the dial colours, the case, the calibre change, the depth rating, the edition sizes and the euro price. Seiko's own global Astron catalogue, read at source the same day, lists neither reference. 8 No October auction result could be read at source this week; the houses' own pages carry estimates and closing dates but no totals. The dates above are as published by the houses.

10× / 10×

WEDNESDAY'S TWO LAUNCHES: BREMONT AT US\$7,400 AND 500M, ARMIN STROM'S EIGHT-PIECE TRIBUTE³ AT CHF 69,000 AND 50M — TEN TIMES THE PRICE FOR A TENTH OF THE DEPTH⁵

THE CHATTER · TWO THREADS, ONE AFTERNOON

The comment thread opened hostile and stayed there: **"Overpriced and not that competitive"**

(DanielWalsh1294), **"A decent watch at a third of the price"** (MarkBu). A rival title ran the same watch the same day and drew exactly one comment: **"Sharp looking watch. The haters will be here shortly."**⁶

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT 500M BUYS

Brandon Moore, in SJX's hands-on, finds the movement **"somewhat outgunned in this peer group"** and doubts the helium valve earns its hole in the case. On the orange "London" printed at six, he is blunter: it **"feels misleading"**, and is **"conceptually annoying, but not a deal-breaker"**. A ceramic case and a 500m rating are real engineering. Neither is what the extra four hundred and fifty dollars buys.¹

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Seiko Astron HAB009 and HAB010 — 1,500 pieces each, €3,200, calibre 5X63, **100m**. The press pictures reached the magazines before the catalogue: neither reference appears on Seiko's own site.⁷

Armin Strom Tribute³ Au750 — 38mm rose gold, eight pieces, CHF 69,000 and no second currency published anywhere. Its own spec sheet prints lug-to-lug as **18mm**, which is the lug width.⁵

October's auctions stay held for a third issue. Phillips New York closes today without totals; Sotheby's Paris sold on the 7th and published none. The Singapore hook is Sotheby's Collectors' Edit, 21–28 October.⁸

SCREEN & SOUND · THE SORKIN SEQUEL

Two scores, one film, and a review count nobody prints

The Social Reckoning opens today on sixty-one per cent from a hundred and twenty critics — and fifty-three from forty-five. Every weekend figure in circulation is a forecast.

Aaron Sorkin's *The Social Reckoning* goes wide today: Columbia, rated R, one hour fifty-two, with Mikey Madison as the whistleblower Frances Haugen, Jeremy Allen White as the reporter who published her, and Jeremy Strong as Mark Zuckerberg.¹

It arrives with two numbers that are not comparable and will be compared anyway. Rotten Tomatoes has it at **61% from 120 critics**. Metacritic has **53 from 45** — twenty positive, twenty mixed, five negative. The review counts differ by a factor of 2.7, and the tomato figure moved about two points inside a week as the count filled. Print the denominator or do not print the score.²

There is no box office. The tracking page carries dashes in every column — no opening, no theatre count, nothing flagged estimate. What is circulating is forecast: roughly **US\$8m** on about **2,200** screens from one trade outlet, a **\$6m to \$10m** range from a second, **\$7–8m** from a third, **\$5m** from a fourth. For scale, *The Social Network* opened at **US\$23m** in 2010, in dollars of that year. This magazine printed a correction two issues ago for treating Sunday estimates as finals; it is not repeating the lesson.³

Last weekend's actuals carry the better fact. Across 67 films reporting a total of **US\$98,695,421**, an Indian sequel opened on **541 screens for \$2,740,000 — \$5,064 a screen** — against a wide release taking \$7,201,655 on **3,555** screens, or **\$2,025**. One-seventh of the footprint, two and a half times the yield. The steepest fall in the top six was 58%.⁴

And on the album chart, a split worth more than either artist. On the sales chart for the week to 8 October a debut took first place while Taylor Swift's year-old record sat **second in its fiftieth week**, up from 189th. The same album holds the combined

chart, which counts streams. **No units figure is published on the sales page at all**, so the structural story is printable and the artist's own numbers remain, as for three issues, unavailable.⁵

\$5,064

PER-SCREEN AVERAGE ON 541 SCREENS LAST WEEKEND — TWO AND A HALF TIMES THE FIGURE A 3,555-SCREEN RELEASE MANAGED⁴

THE CHATTER · THE COMPLAINT IS THE DIRECTING

The early audience read is unusually specific, and it is not about the writing. Reviewers praise the pace and the dialogue and then land on the chair: one critic writes that Sorkin is too good a writer to be working with Sorkin the director. The consistent praise across the thread is for Strong's performance. The audience score does not exist yet: the popcorn meter shows **no rating at all**, from zero verified users, on a film opening today.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THREE CRITICS, ON THE RECORD

Oscar Goff, two and a half out of four: **"With no outside director to temper his voice, Sorkin's worst impulses are left unchecked."** Wendy Ide, in *The Observer*: the film **"does not have the original's punchy impact."** And the harshest on the aggregator, from Nina Starnier: **"It's a poorly performed, directed, and written slog of a film."** Those three sit inside the same 61% as the favourable notices, which is what a proportion does and an average does not.²

ALSO REPORTING

A Technics anniversary deck, 12,000 units at US\$1,599.99, serial-numbered on the gold edition. The trade verdict is the useful one — the maker **"has dressed the MK7 for the party"** and it is **"not a technical reinvention"**; the specification is the existing one. It shipped in September, so it is a peg rather than a launch.⁷

SOURCES 1 Cast, credits, certificate, running time and release date from the studio's own character posters and from the film's tracking page, both read at source; the poster carries the 9 October date. 2 Both aggregate scores, both review counts, the Metacritic distribution and the three quoted notices read at source on the aggregators' own pages, 9 October 2026. The movement in the tomato figure during the week is a search-summary observation and is reported as approximate. 3 The tracking page's empty columns were read at source. All four forecasts are search summaries from trade outlets whose own pages refused this desk — one returned 403 and three redirected to a paywall — and they are printed as forecasts, attributed to no single house, precisely because none could be read. The 2010 comparison is nominal and is labelled as such. 4 The weekend chart for 2 to 4 October 2026, read at source, including the reporting-film count and the aggregate total; the two per-screen figures are this desk's division. The chart page carries no estimate-or-final label, so the figures are described as last weekend's rather than as audited. 5 The official sales chart for the week to 8 October 2026, read at source, for the placings, the prior-week position and the week count; the page publishes no unit figures, which is why none appears here. 6 The Letterboxd consensus is characterised from several reviews read in summary rather than quoted from individual pages, except the phrase attributed, which is a critic's own; the absent audience score was read at source. 7 The maker's own product page for the edition size, price and specification, and a trade review of 2026 for both quoted judgements, both read at source.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE THRESHOLD AT TWELVE

She crossed a line in July and no letter came

Singapore's paediatric advice says under-twelves should avoid caffeine and twelve to eighteens may have a hundred milligrams. The ministry also says it collects no data on either side of that line.

In a written answer to Parliament this week, the health ministry set out the local paediatric position in one sentence: **“children under 12 years of age should avoid caffeine, while adolescents aged 12 to 18 years should consume no more than 100mg of caffeine per day”** — about one cup of coffee. The ministry **“does not collect data”** on how many children or young people have sought medical attention over caffeine. It **“has not conducted studies”** on the effects in that age group, on the ground that these are well documented internationally.¹

Its reassurance is narrower than it reads. High-caffeine energy drinks have been **under 1% of sweetened-beverage sales since 2017** and are not sold in schools, failing the healthier-choice criteria — a real figure about a category that is not the one a twelve-year-old drinks. The ministry said it did not rule out further measures should its risk assessment change.¹

The timing is awkward twice over. The ministry's screen-use guidance runs from birth **to twelve**. She ages out of it next July, and this desk could not find the document that replaces it.²

The week's better evidence is not about drinks at all. A cohort study published on 22 September followed **9,476 children** whose brains were imaged at ten and whose experiences were tracked to thirteen — a band that actually contains a twelve-year-old, which most of the cited literature does not.³

It found reduced right hippocampal volume associated with persistent distressing unusual experiences, at an adjusted odds ratio of **0.91 per standard deviation, with a confidence interval of 0.85 to 0.98**. The usable part is the interaction: **team-sports participation moderated it**, at 1.07 with an

interval of 1.01 to 1.14, and at one standard deviation above the mean of participation the association was no longer detectable.³

Read it carefully before acting. It is observational, so direction is unestablished; activity was **reported by parents at a single point**, at age ten; the outcome is a questionnaire, not a diagnosis. And the moderation is small, its lower bound at 1.01 — in ten thousand children with many candidate moderators, the kind of finding that does not always replicate.³

100mg

THE DAILY CAFFEINE CEILING SINGAPORE'S PAEDIATRIC ADVICE SETS FOR TWELVE- TO EIGHTEEN-YEAR-OLDS — AGAINST “AVOID” FOR THE YEAR BEFORE¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PARLIAMENTARY RECORD ACTUALLY ASKS

The questions are more pointed than the reply. One asked for mandatory milligram-per-serving labelling and a standardised front-of-pack advisory; another, whether the ministry would publish consumption guidelines for young people at all. The reply concedes there is no recognised health-based guidance to publish — an unusual thing for a health ministry to put in writing, and a better answer than a reassuring one.¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE CATEGORY THE FIGURE MISSES

Energy drinks at under one per cent of sweetened-beverage sales is the right answer to the wrong question. The caffeine a Singaporean twelve-year-old actually meets arrives in bubble tea, which that statistic does not cover, and in coffee-flavoured everything. This desk could not read the consumer association's recent advisory on youth caffeine — its site refused — so no figure from it is printed here.²

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Health, written answers to parliamentary questions at the sitting of 7 October 2026, published 8 October and read at source; all four quotations, the sales share, the schools position, the questions asked and the closing undertaking are its own words. 2 The screen-use guidance age range is as published by the ministry and reported in search summaries; its own page and the national health portal both returned 404 to this desk, so the range is carried on that basis and the absence of a successor document is stated as a failure to find one, not as a finding. The consumer association's site returned a bot challenge. 3 Ku, Arrant, Damme and Walker, “Hippocampal volume and persistent distressing psychotic-like experiences across early adolescence: the moderating role of physical activity”, *Schizophrenia Research*, published 22 September 2026, doi 10.1016/j.schres.2026.09.021; the structured abstract was retrieved in full through the National Library of Medicine's own interface after the publisher's page proved unreadable. The sample, the age band, both odds ratios with their intervals and the interaction result are the paper's own; the limitations in the final paragraph are drawn from its own design description and from this desk's reading of the interval, and the caution about replication is this desk's judgement, not the authors'. **This desk prints general guidance, not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS • THE CASE FOR WAITING

Studying makes them unhappier than social media does

Seven million observations across a hundred and eighty-two countries put the effect of social media on a teenager's mood at minus two per cent. Studying came in at minus seven.

The loudest argument in parenting has an unfashionable counterweight, and she has the biggest datasets. Across **355,358 adolescents** in three datasets, she and a colleague found the association **“negative but small, explaining at most 0.4% of the variation in well-being”** – and concluded **“these effects are too small to warrant policy change”**.¹

A 2025 study put the same question to people in the moment rather than in retrospect: **7.1 million observations from 191,672 users across 182 countries**. When respondents felt social media was affecting them, their well-being at that moment was **“reduced by 2%”** against their own average. The comparisons in the same paper are what make it quotable: **listening to music plus 8%, relaxing plus 6%, health issues minus 8% – and studying minus 7%.**²

By the users' own reckoning, homework is three times worse for a teenager's mood than the thing being legislated against. That is not an argument for unlimited phones. It is an argument about proportion.²

Her summary of the field, in a review of eighty reviews, is harder on the research than on the technology: it is **“dominated by cross-sectional work that is generally of a low quality standard”** and the direction of the link **“is still unclear”**.³

The evidence that would settle it is now being collected. Australia's under-sixteen law took effect on **10 December 2025** – the first national experiment of its kind – and a five-wave evaluation is tracking **4,121 young people aged ten to sixteen.**⁴

For a household with a twelve-year-old here, the position sits where it did: since January the

secondary-school rule bars phone and smartwatch use outside lesson time, recess and co-curricular activities included, and the school learning device locks at **10.30pm**. None of that waits on the research.⁵

0.4%

SHARE OF THE VARIATION IN ADOLESCENT WELL-BEING EXPLAINED BY DIGITAL TECHNOLOGY USE, ACROSS 355,358 YOUNG PEOPLE¹

1,194,000

YOUNG AUSTRALIANS ESTIMATED TO HAVE HAD ACCOUNTS DEACTIVATED WHEN THE UNDER-SIXTEEN LAW TOOK EFFECT ON 10 DECEMBER 2025⁴

THE CHATTER • THE TRIAL THAT WILL DECIDE IT

The Australian evaluation is doing what the debate has never had: five survey waves, opt-in passive tracking of actual phone use, linked health and education records, and a causal method specified in advance. Its cohort runs **ten to sixteen**, so it contains a twelve-year-old throughout. Nothing reports yet – so any confident claim this week about what the ban has done is being made ahead of the instrument built to measure it.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • AGAINST THE SCEPTIC

The honest objection to all of the above is that an average across hundreds of thousands of teenagers can hide a badly affected minority. That is exactly what a separate hundred-day diary study found when it looked: an average effect near zero concealed a positive association for **37.0%** of adolescents and a negative one for **14.2%** – with age, gender and resilience all failing to predict which child fell where. The small average is a true statement about populations and a useless one about your own child.⁶

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

SOURCES 1 Amy Orben leads a programme at the MRC Cognition and Brain Sciences Unit, Cambridge, per her unit's own staff page. Orben and Przybylski, *Nature Human Behaviour*, 14 January 2019, doi 10.1038/s41562-018-0506-1; sample and both quotations from the published abstract, retrieved through the Europe PMC programming interface. 2 Dienlin, Smahel and Orben, *Cyberpsychology, Behavior and Social Networking*, 14 July 2025, doi 10.1177/21522715251359204; the observation and user counts, the country count and all five quoted figures are the paper's own, retrieved the same way. 3 Orben, *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology*, 10 January 2020, doi 10.1007/s00127-019-01825-4, for both quotations; and Goodyear and colleagues, *BMJ*, 27 March 2025, doi 10.1136/bmj-2024-082569, for the title cited. A 2026 commentary by her on a proposed British ban could not be read – the journal returned 403 and no abstract is deposited. 4 Stevic and colleagues, *BMJ Open*, September 2026, doi 10.1136/bmjopen-2026-118912; the commencement date, the cohort size and age band and the design are from the published protocol abstract. It reports no results. 5 The secondary-school restriction and the device curfew were announced on 30 November 2025 and took effect in January 2026; the education ministry's own press page returned 404, so no clause is quoted. 6 The diary study is Siebers and colleagues, as carried in this magazine's No. 124, where it was read at source. **This desk prints general guidance, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK • A WEEK WITHOUT DATA

Oil jumped four per cent and yields fell anyway

One scheduled American release landed all week. So the long end was priced by a missile strike and a term premium at a twelve-year high, not by anything a statistician published.

Start with what did not happen.¹ The missile first. Houthi strikes on two Saudi airports took **Brent up 3.71% to US\$103.92** in a session. And yet across the same window the **ten-year Treasury fell from 5.31% to 5.22%**, with the ten-year real yield down from 2.95 to 2.87 and the implied breakeven moving **2.36 to 2.35**.²

The decomposition this magazine has been running now sits on a falling yield: across 5 to 8 October the nominal fell nine basis points and the real eight, **88.9% real**; from the 7th, 83.3%; from the 1st, 50.0%. Meanwhile the premium set a new high. The New York Fed's ten-year estimate reached **0.9848 on 7 October** against the 0.9621 printed here yesterday — confirming that reading, whose last higher day was 2 July 2014, and moving the record back three further weeks to **11 June 2014**.³

Here is the part worth slowing down for. Over those three days the model's **risk-neutral yield fell 3.69 basis points while the premium rose 2.27**. So one rally decomposes two opposite ways in a week: against inflation-protected securities it was **89% real**; against the term-structure model it happened **only because the expected-rate path fell faster than the premium climbed**.³

The decomposition is window-dependent and the page says so: measured from the 7th it is 83.3% real, from the 1st only 50.0%. Breakeven inflation moved **2.36 to 2.35** across the whole week — inflation compensation did essentially nothing while the oil price rose four per cent.²

Name the regime plainly, because it is most easily got wrong: this is a **tightening** cycle. On 16 September the committee **raised** a quarter point to 3¾–4%, twelve to nothing, and Wednesday's minutes record

SOURCES 1 The Federal Reserve's own meeting calendar and the Bureau of Labor Statistics' own release schedule, both read at source on 9 October 2026. 2 Crude prices from a market data interface, timestamped 8 October 20:59 UTC, read at source. Yields are the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve and daily par real yield curve for October 2026, read at source, latest date 8 October; the breakeven is the difference between the two published series and was corroborated independently against the St Louis Fed's own ten-year breakeven for the same day. The real shares are this desk's arithmetic on those curves. 3 The New York Fed's term-premium workbook, downloaded and read from its daily sheet, whose latest row is 7 October 2026; the 2014 comparisons are this desk's search of the same series, and the risk-neutral and premium changes are differences within it. 4 The committee's own statement of 16 September 2026 and the minutes released 7 October, both read at source; both quotations are theirs. 5 Index levels and the daily series from the same market data interface, read at source; the three banks' moves and the brokerage comments are from two market reports of 8 October, read at source. The three-month check is this desk's own on the six-month daily series. The dates for next Wednesday are from the Monetary Authority's own advance release calendar and the trade ministry's own notice, both read at source. 6 All levels read at source and timestamped 8 October; the fifty-two-week positions are computed by this desk from the same series. Gold is a spot quote at 21:16 UTC and carries no day change because the series read gives none. **This desk explains markets and does not give investment advice.** 7 The French yield and spread from a market-data service, read at source, together with the article on the same host whose headline and data disagree.

“inflation remains elevated” and that Treasury supply was contributing **“to higher term premiums and Treasury yields”**.⁴

Singapore took it squarely: the index fell **3.49% to 5,412.96**, a two-day loss of 5.06%, with the three banks — over a quarter of it — down 4.8 to 5.3%. Next Wednesday brings the policy statement, the Macroeconomic Review, third-quarter output and American consumer prices, all on one day.⁵

THE FOUR THE PAGE TURNS ON

US 10-year	5.22%	▼ 6bp
10-year real	2.87%	▼ 5bp
Term premium	0.9848	▲ 2.3bp
Brent	\$103.92	▲ 3.71%
VWRA	\$192.50	▼ 0.43%
Bitcoin	\$81,689	▼ 1.71%

At Thursday's close; the term premium is 7 October, the latest published. The full strip is on **p2**. Not advice.⁶

THE CHATTER • WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

A global equity fund closed at **192.50**, inside a 4.8% drawdown from its high. The cleanest global-aggregate bond line sits **0.75% above its 52-week low and 6.3% below its high** — the bond bear market in one number. Gold is **26% below** its one-year peak and bitcoin **34% below** its own, both read through the same real yields.⁶

THE SCEPTIC • A NUMBER NOT TO PRINT

The French ten-year closed Thursday at **4.885%**, its spread over Germany at **152 basis points**, the widest since late 2011. A repeated line says it went **“above 5%”** this month — one market-data host carries that claim in a headline while **its own data stream gives 4.92%**. This desk prints the close.⁷

THE RABBIT HOLE · TEN METRES, HALF A MILLIMETRE

The hardest target in sport is a white dot

An air-rifle ten-ring is half a millimetre across at ten metres. The men's air-pistol qualification record has stood since 2009 — and in Singapore the gun has to live at the club.

Open the rule book at the target diagrams and the discipline explains itself in two numbers. The ten-ring on a 10m air-pistol target is **11.5mm** across. On a 10m air-rifle target it is **0.5mm** — a printed dot, thinner than the pencil you would mark it with.¹

Scoring is by outward gauge: a 4.5mm pellet counts if its hole breaks the line. So the real tolerance is ring plus pellet — **16.0mm** for pistol, **5.0mm** for rifle, or **5.5** and **1.72 arc-minutes**. The painted rifle dot alone subtends about **ten arc-seconds**. A 10.9 means the pellet's centre arrived within a quarter of a millimetre of the middle, from ten metres, standing, unsupported.²

Sixty shots, seventy-five minutes, one hand for pistol. The final is eight shooters: two series of five at 250 seconds, then **fourteen single shots at fifty seconds each, on command**, the lowest eliminated from the twelfth and after every two thereafter.³

Why it is hard is measurable, and a Spanish group measured it. Tracking 360 shots from one elite shooter, they found the aim point moving at **108.8 millimetres a second in the final second before release** — the muzzle never stops, travelling about the width of the target card every second.⁴

The equipment rules match. A pistol must break at no less than **500 grams** and fit a box **420 by 200 by 50 millimetres**; triggers are weighed at random straight after the last series.⁵

Singapore is where this gets genuinely unusual, because the law here treats an air pistol as a gun. Under the Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act the police licensing guideline sets six conditions for a sporting possession licence, and the fifth is flat: **"All guns must be stored in the approved armoury at the shooting club."** There is no version of this hobby where the thing lives in your house.⁶

Which inverts the order of buying. A beginner takes a **Possess-Use Licence** for the club's pool guns. The ten-metre venue is the air-weapons range at SAFRA Yishun — **33 bays** on electronic targets. Membership runs **S\$78 a year** for SAFRA members, **S\$196** otherwise; the six-lesson basic course is **S\$297.75**. Club first, licence second, gun last or never.⁷

594 / 600

THE MEN'S 10M AIR-PISTOL QUALIFICATION WORLD RECORD, SET AT CHANGWON ON 12 APRIL 2009 — UNBEATEN THROUGH FOUR OLYMPIC CYCLES⁸

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE NEWCOMERS COME FROM

The funnel is the Olympic broadcast, and the arrivals say so. One poster opened a thread in August 2024 with **"Where do I start?"** A second, in northern British Columbia, found everything **"super expensive"**, had hoped for **"the \$600 CAD range"**, and reported his nearest ISSF club **1,155km** away. Another called it **"a true lifetime sport"** and, told it would not be easy, replied: **"If it were easy, would it be worth the effort?"**⁹

THE SCEPTIC · THE PAPER THAT ARGUES WITH ITS OWN FIELD

Everyone teaches that holding still is the skill. The study above found otherwise in its elite subject: relations between stability of hold and performance **"oscillated between 2 and 3%"**, and it concluded that **"stability of hold does not seem to be a determining factor of the score"**. That contradicts the literature it cites, which put hold at **33%** of score variance in pistol and **54%** in rifle. Sway predicts performance in novices; in elites it stops predicting. One shooter is not a sample, and the authors say so.⁴

What follows goes down: the gear ladder and where it stops buying points, the custom-grip world and its six-month waits, the pellet economy, and the rule change that had a global community taking a rasp to two-hundred-euro walnut.

SOURCES 1 ISSF Rule Book, Edition 2025 (second print, July 2026), effective 1 July 2026, rules 6.3.4.3 and 6.3.4.6; the 504-page document was downloaded and its text extracted locally, so every dimension here is a transcription rather than a secondary report. 2 The effective-tolerance and angular figures are this desk's arithmetic from those ring diameters and the 4.5mm calibre specified in the same book; they are offered as a working-out, not as published ISSF figures. 3 Course of fire and final format from the same book, rules 7.7.4, 8.11, 6.17.1 and 6.17.2. 4 Mon-López, de la Rubia, García-Aliaga, Acebes-Sánchez, Refoyo Roman and Lorenzo Calvo, "Optoelectronic analysis of technical factors and performance of elite-level air pistol shooting", *PLoS One* 2022;17(1):e0262276, read in full at the PubMed Central deposit. The trace speed, the ring-dwell percentages, both quoted conclusions and the cited comparison figures are the paper's own. 5 Rule book, 8.4.1.5, 8.4.2 to 8.4.2.3, 8.12 and 7.7.5. 6 Singapore Police Force, guideline on application for a gun licence, downloaded and read; the statute named in its own appendix is the Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act 2021, and the six criteria and the quoted clause are verbatim. The Act's own text could not be read — the statutes site returned 403. 7 The same police guideline for the use-licence route; the range description, the membership rates and the course fee are from the operator's own pages and the national association's own competition document, all read at source. 8 ISSF records page, dated 1 October 2026, read at source. 9 A thread opened on 2 August 2024 on the discipline's principal forum, read at source; posters are quoted as they sign themselves.

THE DEEP END • THE GEAR LADDER

Almost none of it will make you shoot better

The quality entry point is a current match pistol at about fifteen hundred dollars. Everything above that buys fit, balance and serviceability — and the people who own it say so out loud.

There is no cheap-first ladder here worth printing. The real entry is a current-production match pistol, and in the one American dealer still publishing a complete catalogue that means a **Walther LP500 at US\$1,510** or a **Hämmerli AP20 at US\$1,080** from the maker's own list.¹

From there the climb is steep and short. Feinwerkbau's **P11 from €1,619** and **P8X from €2,225**; the **Steyr evo 10 at US\$2,850** and **LP50 at US\$3,070**; **Morini's CM162EI at US\$3,200**; **Pardini's K12 at US\$3,699**.¹

Rifle costs more and the gap is wider. The serious entry is a **Hämmerli AR20 Pro at US\$1,350** or Feinwerkbau's new aluminium-stocked **NEXUS Flex at €1,999**; the top of Walther's own list is the **LG500 iTec Anatomic at US\$6,905**.²

Then the cost nobody counts. Rifle clothing is a second gun: a Monard suit runs **€1,945 to €2,500**, a Kurt Thune jacket **€1,195** and its trousers **€833**, before boots at **£250**. Every garment is governed to the millimetre — jackets and trousers **2.5mm single, 5.0mm double**, shoes 4.0, gloves 16.0 — and stiffness is tested by a cylinder that must sink **3mm within fifteen seconds**. Resubmission costs **€20**; fail three times and the garment cannot be used at all.³

Sights are the quiet money. A Centra Spy is **US\$609.95**; a Gehmann iris with corrective diopter **US\$521.95**. Gehmann's own catalogue is the deepest in the world — twenty-two variants of rearsight iris alone — and publishes **no prices whatsoever**.⁴

Pellets are where the obsession concentrates and the returns thin. **Qiang Yuan Olympic at US\$25.95 per 500** is now the dearest match pellet on the American shelf, above Eley Tenex Air at \$21.95 and RWS R10 at \$19.95 — while the same Chinese brand's training

grade sits at **\$10.95**. The serious practice is not buying the dearest tin: one dealer sells **fifty pellets from a single lot for US\$4**, so you test lots in your own barrel and buy that lot deep.⁵

And the sentence governing the second-hand market: a cylinder must be **within ten years of manufacture** or equipment control rejects it. A cheap used pistol with an old bottle is one you will re-cylinder.⁶

US\$1,999

A SCATT MX-W2 OPTOELECTRONIC TRAINER — MORE THAN THE MATCH PISTOL MOST CLUB SHOOTERS ARE AIMING WITH⁷

THE CHATTER • WHAT OWNERS ACTUALLY WARN ABOUT

The Walther LP500 carries the sport's one real reputational problem. A long-standing poster: it is “**a gun made of cheap parts to save manufacturing costs, so it isn't very reliable**”, its adjustable grip “**a disaster**”. A 2025 owner is gentler and lands in the same place: “**don't buy it just because its cheaper.**” The Pardini K12 is loved with one named flaw — “**the trigger needs constant greasing**” — and praised for the opposite reason: “**The recoil absorber is superb.**” Steyr and Morini get the same two words: “**proven performers**”.⁸

THE SCEPTIC • THREE LINES FROM INSIDE THE HOBBY

On choosing between flagships: “**all the top guns will be better and more accurate than the human at the other end.**” On a custom grip costing about €350, after two months of use: “**it hasn't improved my scores at all but looks good lol.**” And to a man in his forties starting out: “**it is your mind trying to deal with stress that keeps you from scoring really good.**” Every one of those is from an owner of good equipment, not from someone arguing against spending.⁹

SOURCES 1 Catalogue prices read at source at a Michigan match dealer publishing a complete current dollar catalogue, and at Walther's and Feinwerkbau's own sites for their own lists; Pardini's price is from a named American dealer's product page. Morini, Steyr and Pardini publish no prices of their own, which is itself why dealer pages are used. A long-cited American house has moved almost its whole catalogue to “call for pricing”, and its one remaining printed figure sits US\$1,310 below another dealer's for the same pistol — so no price here comes from it. 2 Rifle prices from the same Michigan dealer and from Walther's and Feinwerkbau's own lists, all read at source; the identical aluminium and walnut pricing is Feinwerkbau's own. 3 Clothing prices from the makers' own shops (Finland) and a UK specialist, read at source. The thickness, stiffness, resubmission-fee and three-strike provisions are ISSF Rule Book, Edition 2025 (second print, July 2026), 7.5.2.1 to 7.5.2.3, 7.5.4.10 and 6.7.6. 4 Sight prices from an American and a UK specialist, read at source; the catalogue depth and the zero-magnification diopter are from the maker's own English pages. 5 Pellet prices from two American dealers and one UK dealer, read at source; the head sizes and the single-lot sample service are their own listings. 6 ISSF Rule Book 6.7.6(h), which sets the ten-year validity. 7 The maker's own American store, read at source. 8 Owner threads on the discipline's principal forum dated February 2021, May 2024 and February 2025, all read at source; posters are quoted as they sign themselves and none is a reviewer. 9 Three separate posts of February and November 2025 on the same forum, read at source.

THE DEEP END · GRIPS, RULES AND DOUBT

A rule moved by millimetres, and everyone reached for a rasp

The 2026 grip rules fixed three angles. Across the world, shooters began reshaping walnut they had waited six months and three hundred dollars for.

In pistol the custom grip is not a flex; it is the expected endgame, and cheaper than outsiders assume. A Rink custom runs **US\$313** against a Morini factory anatomical at **US\$325**. The custom one costs the same as the catalogue one. What you buy is fit, and a wait.¹

The wait is the folklore. Quoted lead times in one thread ran from **four to eight weeks to twelve to fourteen**, with one owner's taking about four months, which he put down to **"a backlog from new interest in Olympic air pistol"**.²

Which matters more than usual this year, because the rules moved. From 1 July a grip's rear section must be **no longer than 40mm**, angle up by **not less than 45 degrees**, and the heel rest be cut at **30 degrees or more**. The thread that followed is the sport in miniature: one shooter found unmodified grips failing two of the new points days before a competition; a second asked **"It would be great to hear from the manufacturer if their grips are compliant or not"**; a third watched a World Cup broadcast and said **"I dont even know how this is deemed compliant."**³

The same revision drew harder lines elsewhere. A pistol may not be connected to any device during competition except a charger, on pain of disqualification; anything that **actively damps its oscillation before the shot** is banned; and at broadcast events every finalist must now have a **live aiming device fitted** in the call room.⁴

That lands on the one genuinely new object in the sport. Steyr's **evo 10 E SX** puts Bluetooth telemetry inside a match pistol — trigger pull force and dynamics, tilt, tremor, read live on a phone — and the

maker states it is compliant **"only when the Bluetooth connection is inactive, identified by the removed dongle"**. It costs **US\$4,185** against **US\$3,370** for the standard gun: an **\$815 premium** for instrumentation you must disable to compete.⁵

THE CHATTER · WHERE THIS WORLD ACTUALLY LIVES

One board carries the discipline: **225,505 posts across 30,092 topics and 21,388 members**, the Olympic Pistol section alone running to **103,789 posts**. It is hosted by a dealer and funded by donations — the classifieds board asks five to ten dollars if you sell something. Live this month: the grip rules, a postal league, leaking Morinis and Soviet-era pistols. Reddit could not be read at all, so no subscriber figure is printed.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THE HONEST SHAPE OF THE MONEY

A full training rig costs more than the gun: a SCATT MX-W2 at **US\$1,999**, a home electronic target system at **US\$14,000**, a world-cup entry **€170**. Against that, Singapore's national competition charges **S\$26 per event**, caps each at **30 shooters** — and has cut from eleven events in 2025 to **seven in 2026**, with 25m and 50m now closed to everyone outside the national team "due to lane limitations". The constraint here is not money. It is lanes.⁷

NEXT DESCENTS

Leathercraft — veg-tan against chrome, the saddle stitch, and a tool roll that outlives the maker.

Tropical fish & planted aquascaping — carbon dioxide, substrate chemistry and a Japanese design tradition.

SDR & signal hunting — a thirty-dollar stick, a waterfall display, and the whole spectrum to identify.

SOURCES 1 Grip prices from an American match dealer's own listings, read at source. 2 Posts of February and October 2025 and February 2026 on the discipline's principal forum, read at source; the lead times, the fitting account, the scanning and CNC description, the euro figure and the adjustability argument are the posters' own, quoted as they sign themselves. The German grip-maker publishes neither prices nor lead times, which is why both come from buyers. 3 ISSF Rule Book, Edition 2025 (second print, July 2026), 8.4.1.5(c) to (g) for the three measurements; the four quoted reactions are from a thread running from 30 December 2025 to late January 2026, read at source. 4 Same rule book, 8.4.1.3(f), 8.4.1.4, 6.7.4.5 and 8.4.1.7. 5 Steyr's own product pages for the system, its claimed functions, the compliance condition quoted and the shot-count comparison; both prices from the American dealer at note 1. No launch date is published by the maker or any dealer, so the pistol is described as current rather than dated. 6 Board statistics read off the forum index on 8 October 2026, together with its own self-description and donation notice. Every route to Reddit was refused, so no subscriber count appears on this page. 7 Trainer and target prices from the makers' own stores; the entry fee from the ISSF Rule Book, 3.8.4.2. The Singapore figures, the participant caps, the entry limits, the reduction from eleven events to seven and the quoted lane explanation are from the national association's own competition instructions for 2026, downloaded and read.

FITNESS · THE CHRONOTYPE TRIAL

Train at your best hour. It changes nothing

The claim every wearable sells finally got a double-blind trial, and the answer rounds to zero. The paper that delivered it cannot keep its own dropout count straight.

A Basel group profiled each volunteer's performance across the day, found the hour they were strongest and the hour they were weakest, then randomised them to lift at one or the other. Three arms, two to two to one, **108 people**, twelve weeks, two supervised resistance sessions and one cycling session a week.¹

Peak against trough, on the primary measure — relative isometric mid-thigh pull — came to **0.06 N·kg⁻¹, with a confidence interval running from -0.76 to 0.88**. Grip returned -0.21 (-0.68 to 0.26); appendicular lean mass index 0.03 (-0.09 to 0.15). The authors' own sentence: aligning training with an individual's peak performance time of day **"did not enhance skeletal muscle adaptations"**.¹

It earns the page because of what it tests. Chronotype timing is sold by watch apps on a literature of crossovers in undergraduates. This put it to older adults, individually profiled, blind to their arm, powered to detect an **8% greater strength gain**. Nothing of that size was there.¹

Then the bookkeeping. The paper reports dropout of **"14% in the peak group, 5% in the trough group and 5% in the control group"**. Two sentences later, in the same paragraph, it lists the peak group's departures as **eight women and three men**. Against a peak arm of forty-four, eleven is **25%**; fourteen per cent of forty-four is six. The per-arm figures that would settle it appear only inside a figure.²

One more: the abstract prints grip strength in **kg·m⁻²**, the unit of the lean-mass index immediately beneath it. Neither slip touches the finding, which is null and robust to both — but this is the paper that will be cited to close the question, and the abstract is the version most people read.¹

9 of 15

WITHDRAWALS THAT WERE MUSCULOSKELETAL COMPLAINTS
— AGAINST FIVE UNRELATED MEDICAL EVENTS AND ONE
WHO FOUND IT TOOK TOO MUCH TIME²

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT THAT IS LIVE

No forum thread on this trial surfaced anywhere this desk looked, which is itself the finding: the chronotype claim is marketed, not debated. What the field argues about this fortnight is muscle and GLP-1 drugs — and two reviews published inside eight days **disagree**. One puts lean mass at **10–30%** of total weight lost across ten studies; the other at **25–30%**. The first concedes its evidence rests on bioelectrical impedance rather than DXA, **with no functional outcomes measured at all**.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE AUTHORS, ON THEMSELVES

Their own limitations are the strongest case against them. Peak and trough were derived from **a single four-day profile**, which may have blunted the contrast the trial was built to detect. Participants were healthy, high-functioning volunteers aged 60 to 80 at one centre. After a two-week familiarisation only about ten weeks of progressive overload remained, so most of what was measured is neural. And the lean-mass differences, they note, **may lie inside the measurement variability of the scanner itself**.¹

ALSO THIS WEEK

Beetroot juice, twelve weeks, nothing. Twenty-seven adults, mean age **56**, randomised to roughly 13 mmol of nitrate daily or a nitrate-depleted placebo alongside supervised lifting twice a week. The training raised citrate synthase activity and most leg-extensor measures; the juice added nothing to any of them — though its abstract publishes no effect sizes, so it clears a lower bar than the trial above.⁴

NULL RESULT

N=108

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

SOURCES 1 Bruggisser, Ritter, Roth, Ritter, Infanger, Ledergerber, Hinrichs, Scheer, Handschin, Hanssen and Knaier, "Effects of Daily Rhythm-Aligned Training on Skeletal Muscle Adaptation in Older Adults: A Randomized Controlled Trial", *Journal of Cachexia, Sarcopenia and Muscle* 17(5): e70390, first published 1 October 2026, doi 10.1002/jcsm.70390, trial registration NCT06063135. Open access; read in full at the PubMed Central deposit, the publisher's own page having returned 403 to this desk. Design, randomisation ratio, session structure, sample, mean age and sex split, all three effect sizes with their intervals, the powering assumption, the conclusion sentence, the limitations and the unit as printed are the paper's own. 2 The dropout percentages, the eight-women-and-three-men breakdown and the withdrawal reasons are from the same paper's results section; the arm size of forty-four is from its table 1. The reconciliation — that eleven of forty-four is 25% against a stated 14% — is this desk's arithmetic on the paper's own two figures, and is offered as a discrepancy to be resolved, not as a correction to the trial's finding, which does not depend on it. 3 Wilkinson and Ramzan, *Current Medical Research and Opinion*, published online 28 September 2026, doi 10.1080/03007995.2026.2734645, for the ten-study range and the measurement caveat; Cuggy and O'Broin, *Aesthetic Surgery Journal Open Forum* 8: ojag163, 29 September 2026, doi 10.1093/asjof/0jag163, for the higher range, which that paper itself labels level-5 evidence. Both read through the Europe PMC programming interface after the article pages returned 403. The absence of forum discussion is reported as an absence: searches of the general fitness communities returned trial registrations and a preprint, and no thread. 4 Mueller and colleagues, *European Journal of Applied Physiology*, online ahead of print 3 October 2026, doi 10.1007/s00421-026-06460-x; abstract read at source, full text subscription-only, which is why no effect size is quoted. **This desk prints general guidance, not medical advice.**

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

Every November sumo ticket is gone, and there is no door

Each row below was put back to a promoter, a venue or an official box office. Two of the biggest names in the window publish no price at all, and one festival has not announced itself.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

9–11 OCT ★ **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix**
MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT, ROUND SEVENTEEN; FIRST PRACTICE TONIGHT. PRICES WERE NOT OBTAINABLE — THE PROMOTER'S PAGE RENDERS WITHOUT THEM — AND 2027 HOSPITALITY IS ALREADY SELLING¹

25 NOV ★ **Guns N' Roses — World Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM, DOORS 6PM. ON SALE SINCE MARCH. **FACE VALUES ARE NOT PUBLISHED** ON THE VENUE'S OWN PAGE — ONLY BOOKING FEES, S\$6 TO S\$10. RESOLD TICKETS ARE REFUSED AT THE GATE²

17–22 DEC ★ **BTS — World Tour, four nights**
NATIONAL STADIUM, FOUR NIGHTS. **VIP S\$388 DOWN TO S\$148** PLUS BOOKING FEE. AGGREGATORS REPORT ALL FOUR SOLD OUT; **THE VENUE POSTS NO SELL-OUT NOTICE**²

10–13 DEC ★ **PGL Counter-Strike Major — finals**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM. **S\$144 THURSDAY, S\$169 FRIDAY, S\$294 SATURDAY, S\$369 SUNDAY** — THE SAME SEAT, 2.56 TIMES THE PRICE, FOUR DAYS APART.²

13–22 NOV ★ **Singapore Writers Festival**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY. EARLY-BIRD PASS **S\$24, YOUTH PASS S\$12** — A RARE REAL UNDER-SIXTEEN RATE³

20–29 NOV ★ **Kalaa Utsavam — Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE, PRICED PER SHOW: FAMILY THEATRE **FROM S\$40**, DANCE-THEATRE FROM S\$39.60.³

8 NOV ★ **Deepavali — and the Little India light-up**
FALLS ON A SUNDAY. **MONDAY 9 NOVEMBER IS NOT A UNIVERSAL HOLIDAY** — THE MINISTRY MAKES IT ONE ONLY IF YOUR REST DAY FALLS ON THE 8TH, WHICH LISTINGS SITES GET WRONG. FREE, OUTDOORS, BEST IN THE FORTNIGHT BEFORE⁴

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

8–22 NOV ★ **Grand Sumo, Kyushu — sold out**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER. THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN PLATFORM STATES **"TICKETS ARE SOLD OUT ALL DATES"** AND THAT **NONE ARE SOLD ON THE DAY**. SEVEN WEEKS ON SALE, FIFTEEN DAYS GONE⁵

10–24 JAN ★ **Grand Sumo, Hatsu Bashi — the actionable one**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, FIFTEEN DAYS. **ADVANCE SALES OPEN SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER**; NOTHING IS PURCHASABLE BEFORE THEN, AND NO PRICE IS SHOWN.⁵

14 NOV–28 MAR ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO, FOR THE BUILDING'S CENTENARY. ADMISSION NOT PUBLISHED. TWO COMPANION SHOWS THERE, 19 NOV TO 11 JAN, ARE **FREE**⁶

28 OCT–8 FEB ★ **Shōjo Manga Infinity**
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, ROPPONGI — HAGIO, YAMAGISHI AND YAMATO, WHO BUILT MODERN SHŌJO. PRICE NOT PUBLISHED. THE FAMILY PICK, AND IT RUNS THROUGH THE NEW YEAR⁶

4–11 FEB ★ **77th Sapporo Snow Festival**
ŌDŌRI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO, FREE TO ENTER. **CHECK THE JAPANESE SITE** — THE ORGANISER'S ENGLISH PAGES STILL SERVED 2025 CONTENT THIS WEEK.⁷

8 OCT–16 NOV ★ **The First Railway — MoN Takanawa**
TOKYO'S BIG 2026 OPENING, A KENGO KUMA BUILDING WHOSE PROGRAMME TURNS OVER TWICE A YEAR. THE NEXT CHANGE LANDS **END NOVEMBER**, NO DATES YET⁶

PLANNING NOTES

Two patterns outrank any single row. **The National Stadium sells out eight months ahead, inside one week** — fan-club, card, promoter then general sale — and its own pages warn resold tickets are not honoured. And **the foliage calendar runs later than the guidebooks**: the forecaster puts Kyoto's ginkgo at 27 November and its maples at 11 December, a fortnight apart and six days later than Kyoto's own average. Two absences: **Christmas Wonderland has announced no 2026 dates**, and no promoter confirmation of a 2026 ZoukOut exists — neither is listed.⁸

SOURCES 1 The championship's own 2026 calendar for the round and dates, read at source; the Esplanade's own closure notice independently confirms the race weekend. The promoter's ticket page rendered without price data, which is why none is printed. 2 The stadium operator's own event pages for all three Kallang listings, read at source on 8 October 2026, for dates, times, every price band, the booking fees, the transaction limits, the sale history and the resale warning. The sell-out reports for December are aggregator claims and are labelled as such because the venue itself posts none. 3 The festival's own site and the Esplanade's own festival pages, read at source, for dates and every price. 4 The manpower ministry's own public-holiday page, read at source, for the date and for the rest-day condition that several listings sites misreport. 5 The sumo association's own ticket platform, read at source on 8 October 2026, for the quoted sold-out statement, the no-door rule, the January dates and the 5 December on-sale date. 6 Each museum's own exhibition index, read at source; where no admission price appears above, none appears there. 7 The organiser's Japanese site for the 2027 dates and venues; its English site was still serving 2025 content when read, which is why the warning is printed. 8 The two patterns are drawn from the venue and forecaster pages already cited; the foliage dates are the Japan Meteorological Corporation's second forecast of the season, issued 1 October 2026 and read at source. The two absences were checked at the organisers' own sites, one of which still carries a 2025 closure page and the other of which returned 503. No event listed here appears on this magazine's barred-events ledger.

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

A starred chef reopens, without the counter

September brought a Michelin kitchen's second act at Claymore, a Puglian transplant to Sentosa and a sourdough pie house — and November brings a Tokyo counter nobody has eaten at.

AO (Claymore Drive) is the one with a pedigree to spend. Culinary director Araki Takeshi ran a Michelin-starred modern *kappo* that closed at the end of 2025; here he has put the counter away and cooks sharing plates — carpaccios, tatakis, charcoal grills, rice and noodles — Japanese technique aimed at flavours that are not. The reception is warm and specific: a long-running local reviewer scored it **four out of five** in late September, argued the approachable pricing is what will sustain the concept, and gave two complaints, both about the room — tables close together, no private space. Daily 11am to 10pm; no booking system is published, so the contact is the room's own number.¹

Fico at Tanjong Beach Club is a transplant rather than a debut: Mirko Febbrile's Puglian kitchen from East Coast Park, re-laid across **130 seats** on Sentosa with a poolside terrace and a charcoal dome. It opened in late September; book the dedicated reservation slot, not the beach club's general line, which is a different queue.²

Marymount Bakehouse at Upper Thomson is the one with a real verdict, and it is split. The levain runs through everything — pies, pasta, brunch, dessert — from a founder who trained in Switzerland and at a two-star kitchen before starting at home in 2020. The consensus is pies yes, pasta less so: one reviewer rated the gnocchi below the pies, found a four-cheese asparagus pie **"a bit too intense"** and warned the room **feels stuffy when full**. The honest number is the bill: **S\$110.90 became S\$132.97** with service and tax, about **S\$66 a head before coffee**, for a cafe.³

And the one nobody has eaten in. **O/SIO**, at Tanjong Pagar Road, opens on **4 November** — the first international outpost of a Tokyo pasta restaurant,

with mains **from S\$18.80** and a smoked truffle carbonara billed as exclusive to Singapore. There is no review because there is nothing to review. The phrase doing the work in every mention is "Michelin-approved chef", a credential earned in another country and untested in the most competitive two hundred metres of restaurant in this one.⁴

THE BUZZ · THE HONESTY LEDGER

These four sit at three different levels of proof, and the difference matters more than any dish. **AO** and **Marymount Bakehouse** have scored write-ups with named criticisms attached — the close tables, the stuffy room, the gnocchi. **Fico's** Sentosa kitchen has coverage without judgement: opening pieces and hosted tastings, no verdict. **O/SIO** has not opened. A guide that presented the four as equally proven would be selling you two reviews, one press release and a save-the-date.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A ROUNDUP COUNTS AS NEW

Three names carried in this month's "new openings" lists are not new. One opened in **May 2025** — the same outlet reviewed it then, at seven and a half out of ten — and its October mention is a **S\$28 lunch buffet**. A second opened in July. A third is a **format conversion of an existing cafe** under the same owner. None is a debut, and all three would have filled a slot on this page had nobody checked the original dates. The genre's unit of currency is the word "just".⁵

STILL ON THE SHELF

Two openings covered here earlier in the year are now old enough to judge and have not been judged: neither has drawn a scored review in the months since its launch week. This page will return to them when somebody prints a verdict rather than a menu.

TWO REVIEWED

ONE UNOPENED

SOURCES 1 The chef's background, the format, every quoted price and the opening hours from two Singapore food desks' own pieces of 14 and 25 September 2026, read at source; the four-out-of-five score, the pricing argument and both criticisms are the reviewer's own, from a scored review of 26 September. No Michelin Guide entry exists for the room, which is noted rather than inferred. 2 The seat count, the terrace and barbecue dome, the chef and the Bib Gourmand badge from the venue's own pages, read at source; the opening date is a search summary and is given as late September rather than to the day. The menu is published only as documents this desk could not open, so no price is printed for it. 3 The founder's training, the concept, the opening date, the hours, the seat split and every price from the venue's coverage in two Singapore food outlets, read at source; the quoted criticism, the stuffy-room warning, the gnocchi verdict and the full bill with service and tax are from a scored review, read at source. 4 The estate, the generation, the milling, the menu organisation, the brewing time and every price from the room's own site and two food desks' pieces of 30 September and 6 October 2026, all read at source; the two conflicting opening dates are those two outlets', and the venue's own site states only that it is open. 5 The characterisation of which pieces are scored reviews and which are opening coverage or hosted tastings is this desk's, from reading each piece; where a tasting was hosted, the outlet says so itself. The three set-aside venues were each checked against the same outlets' own earlier coverage, which carries the original dates. Every venue on this page was checked against this magazine's table ledger before selection.

THE UNDERCURRENT · MALDIVES AND RASMALÉ

A country ran out of dollars, so it made land

Reserves halved in a single month in April. Five months later the Maldives put five hundred hectares that did not exist in 2023 on the market — on terms its own attorney-general says are not yet an agreement.

The central bank publishes a spreadsheet. In it, one column records official reserve assets month by month, and in 2026 it reads like a cardiogram: **1,026.1** in January, **1,271.6** in February, **1,331.8** in March. Then April: **717.9**. Six hundred and thirteen million US dollars left the Maldives in thirty days. By July the figure was **638.0**, the lowest point in the published monthly series.¹

There is a dull explanation, and it is true. A **US\$500m** sukuk and a **US\$400m** currency swap both fell due that month. External debt service for 2026 runs to **US\$1.7bn** against **US\$630m** in 2025. Central-government loan repayments for January to July came to **MVR 9,347.4m**, up **141%** on the same months a year earlier. Nothing ran; a bill arrived and was paid.²

What makes it a story is what the state had said eight weeks earlier. On **5 February** the president told the Majlis that gross reserves stood “**in excess of USD 1.13 billion**”, “**representing the highest level in the history of our nation**” — and that of the sukuk, “**the USD 150 million portion... shall be discharged using the foreign currency reserves**” held in the sovereign fund, the rest to be refinanced. The April drawdown was four times that portion.³

The Maldives earns dollars and does not keep them. Resorts bill offshore; the rufiyaa is pegged at **15.42**. The finance minister puts national foreign-currency earnings near **US\$5bn** a year, “**much of it not entering the domestic banking system**”. So in 2024 the state legislated them home: resorts were made to convert **US\$500 per tourist arrival, or 20% of**

monthly gross, whichever they chose. It half-worked. **US\$492m** reached the central bank in 2025, out of inflows the president put at **US\$1.2bn**.⁴

“Not even an inch” of Maldivian land, the finance minister says, is being sold.

On **1 September** the screw turned. An amendment in force that day doubled the resort quota to **40% of monthly gross sales**, deleted the per-tourist alternative altogether, and shortened the payment window to the 28th of the following month. Twenty days later the government signed commercial terms on five hundred hectares of new land.⁵

Because a conversion quota only redistributes dollars that already exist. New dollars need a new export, and the Maldives has nothing left to add to the list — tourism, fish, and a constitution whose Article 251 forbids foreign ownership of any part of its territory. So it manufactured territory. Since December 2023, roughly **1,100 hectares** have been dredged out of the Fushidhiggaru lagoon south of the capital and named **Rasmalé**.⁶

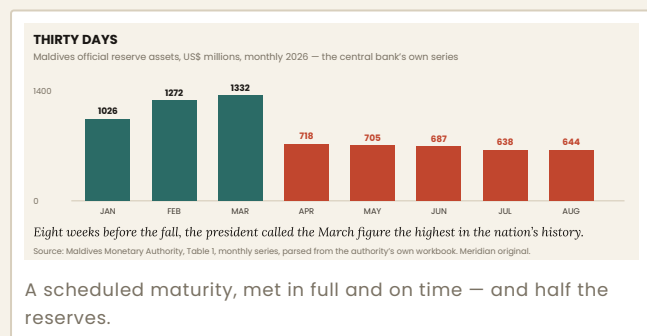
The scale is easier to feel against the old island. Malé is **208.03 hectares** carrying **137,238** residents — **659.7 people per hectare**, among the densest inhabited ground on earth. The whole built capital region, Malé and Hulhumalé and Villingili together, is **659.61 hectares**. Rasmalé is nearly twice all of it. The parcel alone is **2.4 times the island of Malé**.⁷

SOURCES 1 Maldives Monetary Authority, *Table 1: Selected Economic Indicators*, the monthly block, downloaded as a workbook from the authority’s own statistics database and parsed locally by this desk on 9 October 2026; every figure in the first paragraph is read from the column headed “Official reserve assets (USD)”. The six-hundred-and-thirteen-million figure is the subtraction of two adjacent months in that column. The World Bank’s country update of 11 June 2026 gives the same March and April figures to the decimal, which is why they are printed without qualification. 2 The sukuk and swap settlements and the 2026 debt-service total are from that World Bank update; the loan-repayment comparison is from the Ministry of Finance’s *Monthly Fiscal Developments*, series MFD/07/2026, published 13 August 2026, read as a downloaded document. 3 The Presidential Address of 5 February 2026, read at source on the Presidency’s own site; all three quotations and the refinancing arrangement are its own words. 4 The peg is the central bank’s own constant rate in the table at note 1. The five-billion estimate and its quoted qualification are the finance minister’s, in a Maldivian paper of 22 September 2026, read at source. The 2024 conversion quotas are set out in the Monetary Authority’s own published questions-and-answers on the Foreign Currency Act, dated April 2025 and read as a downloaded document — this desk read the regime that was replaced from a primary source, which is why the “before” is stated plainly. The 2025 deposit and inflow figures are the president’s, from the address at note 3. 5 The amendment was ratified on 31 August 2026 and took effect on 1 September; its terms are reported by two Maldivian outlets and were **not** read at source by this desk — the tax authority and the parliament both refused it — so the forty per cent, the deleted option and the deadline are carried on that reporting and flagged here as such. 6 Article 251 as rendered on a constitutional-text archive, not on parliament’s own site, which refused. The dredging start date and the area are discussed at note 1 on the following page, where the competing official figures are set out. 7 Maldives Bureau of Statistics, *Statistical Yearbook 2026*, table 1.5, downloaded and read; the areas, the populations and the density are its own. The comparisons with Rasmalé are this desk’s arithmetic on that table.

On **21 September**, in Abu Dhabi, the Maldivian infrastructure minister and the chairman of Eagle Hills signed commercial terms for a waterfront development on about five hundred hectares of the new land. **10%** of developer revenue on first sales.¹

Then the sentence everything turns on. The developer's own release states that **"upon each transfer, whether through sale or inheritance, a new leasehold term of up to 99 years will commence."** The constitution caps a foreign lease at ninety-nine years. If every sale and every death restarts the clock, no individual lease ever breaches the ceiling and the tenure never ends. It is a constitutional limit defeated by arithmetic rather than by amendment.¹

That reading has to carry a warning, and this desk would rather print the warning than the thesis. The sentence appears in the developer's international release and **was absent from the ministry's Maldivian version**. The attorney-general said on the record on **29 September** that **"so far only a Letter of Intent... has been signed"** and that before work can begin **"relevant laws must be passed by the Majlis"**. The governing real-estate act is still being drafted; the agreement is unpublished. The load-bearing fact of this story lives in a press release, not in an instrument.²



Around that unsigned deal, almost every figure exists in more than one official version. The project is worth **US\$12bn** in the developer's own release and **US\$20bn** when Maldivian ministers describe it. The

reclamation is **1,153** hectares in the original plan, **1,009** on the state housing corporation's reckoning, **about 1,100** from the finance minister. The state's ten-year take is **more than US\$11bn** according to one minister and **more than US\$3bn** according to another. Even the 2025 deficit has two values: **4.3%** of output in the World Bank's update, **5.37%** in the central bank's table.³

It also has a lineage, and every step of it is on the record. In April 2015 they went to ninety-nine, with residency offered for million-dollar investments; that July the constitution itself was amended to permit outright foreign *freehold* on sites at least seventy per cent reclaimed, for projects above a billion dollars. In **April 2019 that amendment was repealed unanimously**. A later government cut the corporate residency threshold to **US\$250,000** and added strata leasing to the tourism act; last year "sustainable townships" were folded into the special-economic-zone framework. Rasmalé is the ninth move in a sixteen-year sequence, not a departure from it.⁵

What changed is which way the pressure runs. Every earlier step tried to attract capital; this one tries to **raise foreign exchange**, and the plumbing says so. Buyers pay into an escrow account held inside the Maldives, depositing dollars into precisely the banking system the conversion regime was written to fill. The land is the instrument; the quota is the pipe.⁵

And the base beneath all of it is shrinking. Tourist arrivals for January to August 2026 came to **1,423,176** against **1,486,926** in the same months of 2025 – down **4.3%**. A forty per cent quota levied on a falling number may simply leave resorts holding rufiyaa they cannot spend.⁴

129.7%

PUBLIC AND PUBLICLY GUARANTEED DEBT AS A SHARE OF OUTPUT IN 2025, ON THE WORLD BANK'S RECKONING – AGAINST RESERVES THAT COVERED ABOUT TWO MONTHS OF IMPORTS BY JULY⁵

SOURCES 1 The commercial-terms release of 21 September 2026, read at source through a verbatim reproduction after the developer's own media pages returned 404 to this desk; the revenue share, the transfer levy, the escrow, the tax treatment and the quoted leasehold sentence are its own words. The absence of a sovereign guarantee, of a loan and of an upfront payment are as reported by the Maldivian press from the infrastructure minister's own account. 2 The attorney-general's remarks are from a Maldivian paper of 29 September 2026, read at source. That the leasehold sentence was missing from the ministry's own version, and that the developer subsequently qualified its website, are reported by a Malé-based outlet on 23 September and 1 October 2026; this desk could not obtain the ministry's text to check it directly, and says so rather than resting the paragraph on an inference. 3 The two project valuations are from the developer's release and from Maldivian ministerial accounts respectively. The competing hectare figures and the two ten-year revenue claims are as compiled by the same Malé-based outlet; the state housing corporation's own site could not be resolved from here, so no figure is preferred over another. The two deficit figures are read at source from the World Bank update of 11 June 2026 and from the central bank's own Table 1. 5 The legal chronology, the 2019 repeal and the later thresholds are as compiled by a Malé-based outlet on 1 October 2026, read at source; this desk did not read the instruments themselves and the sequence is presented as that outlet records it. The escrow arrangement is from the developer's release at note 1. The debt ratio is the World Bank's, from its update of 11 June 2026, read at source; the import-cover figure is this desk's arithmetic on that update's own projection and the reserve series at note 1 on the preceding page. 4 Arrivals are summed by this desk from the monthly column of that same central-bank table for January to August 2026, and for 2025 by subtracting the published September-to-December months from the full-year total. The percentage is the resulting comparison.

The ministers are not evasive about the structure; they are proud of it. The infrastructure minister: **“There is no freehold. Maldivian laws and regulations apply at all times.”** On why the state took a revenue share rather than equity: **“Equity pays only when there is profit.”** And a line that reads like the whole national predicament in nine words — **“Reclaiming land is the cheap part; servicing it is expensive.”** The finance minister insists **“not even an inch”** is sold, then describes what is: **“The lease of these properties can be sold as a trading commodity.”**¹

The developer’s chairman is disarming about his record, promising **“minimum mistakes”** this time, conceding **“we made a lot of mistakes”** before, and adding that if it went badly **“my mother will be very upset”**.¹

The opposition to it is loud, and part of it is ugly enough that a fair account has to say so. A former president held a rally on 27 September promising to kill the deal and hold a referendum, claiming Jews would be brought to Rasmalé; a former vice-president said it paves the way for Jews to enter indirectly. Religious scholars have joined a campaign under the hashtag ending Out. Treating this as a straightforward sovereignty argument would misreport it. The serious objection comes from elsewhere: a former economic development minister notes that the same developer’s projects in Georgia, Serbia and Albania leave the host state roughly a third of each venture, while this one leaves the Maldives none, and calls the absence of an upfront payment **“particularly problematic”** during a dollar shortage.²

“Reclaiming land is the cheap part; servicing it is expensive.”

Serbia is the instructive precedent, because it is the same developer and the same shape. Belgrade Waterfront was built under a project-specific statute passed in 2015 to set bespoke rules on expropriation,

permits and land leasing — precisely the kind of enabling law the Maldivian attorney-general says Rasmalé still needs. The joint company took a ninety-nine-year lease over the site with no lease payment; the Serbian state holds about a third. In April 2016 masked men demolished buildings in the Savamala district overnight; a decade on, the prosecutor’s office has still not identified who they were. This desk read that account in an encyclopaedic source rather than in court records, and flags it as such.³

There is also a Maldivian precedent, and it cuts the other way. In July 2015 the constitution was amended to allow outright foreign freehold on sites at least seventy per cent reclaimed, for investments above a billion dollars. In **April 2019 it was repealed unanimously, and no land was ever sold under it.** The country has announced a scheme of this shape once before and did not execute it.⁴

The number that would settle the argument is the one nobody publishes. The central bank reports gross official reserves; the *usable* figure, historically much smaller, appears in neither its table nor the World Bank’s update. And the institution whose job is to say so has gone quiet: the IMF has published no Maldives staff report since May 2024, the 2025 consultation concluding with the note that **“the authorities need more time to consider the publication of the staff report”**.⁵

So the honest version is narrower than the dramatic one, and more interesting. A state met a scheduled bill in full and on time, and it cost half its reserves. It responded by compelling its resorts to surrender twice as many dollars, and by preparing to sell ground that did not exist three years ago to buyers who cannot legally own it. Whether the lease really renews forever is not yet knowable, because the contract does not yet exist. What is knowable is that the Maldives has begun treating its own exchange rate as a construction project — and that almost every figure attached to the scheme can be found, in an official document, in two sizes.⁶

SOURCES 1 All five ministerial quotations and the three from the developer’s chairman are as reported by a Malé-based English-language outlet on 23 September and 1 October 2026, the chairman’s remarks there sourced in turn to a Gulf daily interview; this desk read the reports, not the interviews. 2 The rally, the two quoted claims about Jewish settlement and the campaign are reported by the same outlet on 1 October 2026; they are printed because an account that omitted them would misdescribe the opposition. The former minister’s comparison and his quoted phrase are from the same report; he is seeking his party’s 2028 presidential nomination, which the reader should weigh. 3 The Belgrade Waterfront account — the 2015 project-specific statute, the unpaid ninety-nine-year lease, the equity split, the April 2016 Savamala demolitions and the unresolved prosecution — is drawn from an encyclopaedic entry and was not verified against the Serbian gazette or any court record. It is offered as a precedent to be checked, not as established fact, and the European human-rights judgment that entry also cites is deliberately not described here for the same reason. 4 The 2015 amendment, its terms and its unanimous repeal in April 2019 are as set out in the legal chronology compiled by the Malé outlet cited above. 5 The absence of a usable-reserves figure is this desk’s own finding from the two documents at notes 1 and 2 on p21. The Fund’s country page was read at source on 9 October 2026: the most recent staff report listed is May 2024, and the quoted sentence accompanies the 2025 Article IV conclusion of 26 March 2025. 6 The closing paragraph makes no claim not sourced on these three pages. Where this desk could not read a document — the amending Act, the signed agreement, the ministry’s own version of the terms, the housing corporation’s area figure — it has said so rather than inferring past it.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

The band with no number

The environment agency publishes four bands for the hourly particulate reading. It puts a number on two of them. For the band above that, the one the West of the island entered at two o'clock this morning, the page gives no concentration at all — only a cross-reference to a daily index the country has not reached.

It is not a cover-up. It is what happens when a scale built for one measurement is asked to carry another and nobody finishes the table. But the effect on a Friday morning is real: a parent deciding about a child's outdoor activity reads the official number, finds it past the top of the only range the agency quantifies, and discovers the next rung is defined by reference to something else.

This issue is full of the same shape. A president called the reserves the highest in his nation's history eight weeks before half of them left. None of these is a lie. Each is a place where someone stopped filling in the table.

Twelve Desks · One World MERIDIAN · No. 127 · 9 October 2026

A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the US Treasury's two daily curves and the New York Fed's term-premium workbook, both as data (p14); the ISSF rule book, downloaded and extracted (p15); four journal papers (p12, p18); a presidential address and a health ministry's written answers (p5, p21); and a venue or box office for every dated row. **Computed here rather than quoted:** the overnight particulate sequence (p5), the real-yield shares (p14), the angular tolerances (p15), and the per-screen averages (p11). **Held, not printed:** Iran's seven conditions, a fourth issue; a Maldivian amending Act and the signed Rasmalé agreement, both refused; Samsung's own guidance release; Singapore prices for four products; and regional hotspot counts, unreachable by a seventh route. **Colophon:** set in Lora and Poppins.